

DU begins allocations for one-year PG programme

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi University has begun seat allocations for its one-year postgraduate (PG) programme, with candidates across 28 departments asked to accept offers by Thursday and pay fees by August 9 after document verification.

Students had earlier raised concerns over the limited number of open seats compared with those offered to graduates of the Four-Year Undergraduate Programme. Seats were later increased from around 1,100 to 2,287. The one-year PG course will also be offered through the School of Open Learning. Further allocation schedules are yet to be announced.

Govt. to repeal B&B law, table 3 Bills, 2 CAG reports in Monsoon Session

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government is set to table a Bill in the upcoming Monsoon Session to repeal the existing law governing the functioning of bed-and-breakfast (B&B) facilities – ‘The National Capital Territory of Delhi (Incredible India) Bed and Breakfast Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2007’ – two months after the fire at a one such facility in Malviya Nagar killed 23 people, including several foreigners.

Making the announcement on Wednesday, Speaker Vijender Gupta said the Assembly’s Business Advisory Committee had decided to table the Bill to repeal the 2007 Act in the four-day session



CM Rekha Gupta chairing a meeting on Wednesday. @CMODELHI/X

starting on Friday.

The committee has also decided to table two other Bills – the Delhi (Right of Citizen to Time Bound and Ease of Delivery of Service) Bill, 2026 and a Bill to amend the existing Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board Act, 2010.

The Speaker added that two reports by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) and a notification

concerning the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission will also be tabled in the House.

New B&B policy

Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra on Wednesday said work is under way on the ‘Delhi Bed & Breakfast Policy, 2026’, whose draft was placed in the public domain on May 26. The draft policy proposes a self-cer-

tification and self-renewal framework, with “deemed approval” within seven working days, down from 30 days in the 2007 law.

“The new policy will be cleared by the Cabinet within a month. During this period – between the repeal of the existing Act and the enactment of the new policy – the Centre’s rules on B&Bs will apply in Delhi,” the Minister told *The Hindu*. He said the process to repeal the 2007 Act has been going on for nearly a year, as many of its provisions have become outdated. “If necessary, we will promulgate the new policy as an ordinance,” said Mr. Mishra.

The Delhi government is also working on a draft Delhi Ease of Doing Business Bill, 2026.

L-G asks DDA to use land to promote city’s heritage and culture

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Lieutenant-Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to explore the use of its land for cultural and creative activities. He also asked the urban body and the Tourism Department to prepare an action plan to promote the Capital’s heritage, arts and design traditions.

As per a Lok Niwas statement, the L-G chaired a meeting with DDA and Tourism Department officials, during which he asked officials from the DDA to examine how its public spaces could be used for art installations, performances and other



L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu chaired a meeting of DDA and Tourism Department officials on Wednesday. ANI

heritage-linked activities.

He directed the departments concerned to identify actionable measures to take the proposals forward in the coming months. Such events could become recurring fixtures on Delhi’s cultural calendar, attracting visitors while providing opportunities for artists and small businesses, said Mr. Sandhu.

AIIMS recalled syringes after quality complaints, says Ministry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi, recalled certain batches of disposable syringes earlier this year as a precaution after receiving quality-related complaints from user departments, the Union Health Ministry informed Parliament on Wednesday.

In a written reply to a question raised by MP Haris Beeran in the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Health Prataprao Jadhav stated that Noble Pharmaceutical Ltd. and Veekay Surgicals manufactured the affected batches. No adverse effects on patients had been reported due to the affected batches, he said.

DERECTORATE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION, GOVERNMENT OF MADHYA PRADESH
Satpura Bhawan, 6th floor, M.P. Bhopal

E-mail: dme12001@yahoo.com, Tel. 0755-2550186, website www.medicaleducation.mp.gov.in
No. 3038/4/UG/DME/2026 Bhopal, dated 3/08/2026

ADVERTISEMENT

Information regarding registration for Online counselling & admission on all State Quota Seats in Government, Autonomous & Private Medical and Dental Colleges including NRI Seats in Private Colleges - NEET U.G. 2026

Registration Process will commence from **05-08-2026 and will continue till 13-08-2026 upto 11:59 PM** for Online counselling & admission on all state quota seats in Government/autonomous/Private Medical & Dental Colleges including NRI Seats on the basis on NEET U.G. 2026 result and under Madhya Pradesh Chikitsa Shiksha Pravesh Niyam 2018 & Amendments issued from time to time. Registration and Counselling process shall be conducted on designated portal <https://dme.mponline.gov.in>.

Detailed time schedule for the counselling shall be published on Directorate of Medical Education website www.medicaleducation.mp.gov.in and also on designated portal <https://dme.mponline.gov.in>.

Candidates are advised to remain in contact with D.M.E website & M.P. online portal for counselling related information.

Director of Medical Education, Madhya Pradesh
Tel. 0755-2550186

Government of Himachal Pradesh
Jal Shakti Department
"Notice Inviting e-tender"

The Executive Engineer Jal Shakti Vibhag Division Nalagarh invites online tenders on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh from approved eligible contractors for the following work (s) through e-tendering process:-

Sr No	Name of work	Estimated Cost	Earnest Money	Stipulated Time Limit	Cost of tender forms
1.	Construction of LIS of Village Bela Salehra, Kundlu, Thoda, Baroona, Khillian Pahari Bas, Jagatpur and Joghon etc. in Tehsil Nalagarh, District Solan HP (Sub Head- Construction of pump house cum attendant quarter, provision of electrical fitting in pump houses, construction of main delivery tanks, construction of field out lets, laying jointing and testing of GMS pipe conforming to BIS 1239 in Rising main, laying jointing and testing of HDPE pipe conforming to IS 4984-2016 in distribution system, supply erection of submersible and centrifugal pumping machinery alongwith its all allied accessories, construction of Sumpwell, construction of wire crates for diversion bandh and feeder channel, construction of boundary walls around the pump houses, providing installing electromagnetic flow meters) Under NABARD, Job No. 2.	1,39,76,639/-	2,14,800/-	Nine Months	5000/-

1Last date of filing / uploading the tender through e-tendering: - **14-08-2026 upto 11:00 AM.**
The tender forms and other detailed conditions can be obtained from the website www.hpiph.org.

HP / 2428/26-2/ **HIM SUCHNA AVAM JAN SAMPARK** Executive Engineer, JSDVn, Nalagarh, District Solan (HP).

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LEGAL NOTICE

STATE CONSUMER DISPUTES REDRESSAL COMMISSION
'A' BLOCK 1ST FLOOR, VIKAS BHAWAN, IST ESTATE, NEW DELHI-110002
NO.C-680/2019/B-2/ DATED 05/08/2026

In the matter of:
RAJESH VARMA
VS.
A.J.S. BUILDERS LTD.

1. A.J.S. Builders Ltd. Having its Corporate Office At: 8 Shaheed Bhagat Singh Marg, Gole Market I Floor, New Delhi-110001

2. A.J.S. Builders Ltd. Having its Registered Office at: 805, antriksh Bhawan, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

3. Ms. Madhu Singh Director A.J.S. Builders, 8 Shaheed Bhagat Singh Marg, Gole Market I Floor, New Delhi-110001

4. Ms. Kailash Rani Director A.J.S. Builders, 8 Shaheed Bhagat Singh Marg, Gole Market I Floor, New Delhi-110001

5. Ms. Geeta Singh Director A.J.S. Builders, 8 Shaheed Bhagat Singh Marg, Gole Market I Floor, New Delhi-110001

Whereas an appeal/complaint against you has been made to this Commission for adjudication. In compliance of the order dated **11/05/2026** and **14/07/2026**, the Appellant/Complainant are hereby directed to effect Substituted service of Summons upon the Respondent/ Opposite Party by way of publication in the newspaper **"Veer Arjun"** in Hindi Language as well as **"The Hindu"** in English Language to appear in this Commission in person or by a pleader or an authorized representative duly instructed and able to answer all the material question in relation to the appeal/complaint on **27/11/2026 at 10:30 a.m.** sharp.

The Appellant/Complainant is further directed to file an Affidavit stating that the service has been effected on the Respondent/Opposite Party by way of publication before the next date of hearing.

Giver under my hand and the seal of this Commission on this **05/08/2026**

REGISTRAR
State Commission
A-Block, Vikas Bhawan
New Delhi-110002

LEGAL NOTICE

BEFORE THE HONOURABLE DISTRICT CONSUMER DISPUTES REDRESSAL COMMISSION - I AT VISAKHAPATNAM
C.C. 491 OF 2025

Between:
Sri Godavarthi Ananda Rao & ...Complainants
And:
M/s. Care Health Insurance Ltd & another Opposite Parties To
M/s. Flak India Private Limited represented by its Authorized Officer, Claims Department, Upper Floor, The Peach Tree, Block-C, Sushant Lok - I, Sector-43, Gurgaon – 122 015.
.... Second Opposite Party

NOTICE

Please take notice that the above Consumer Complaint is filed by the Complainants for a direction against Opposite Parties to pay the medical bills and other reliefs and the same is posted to **20-08-2026**, for your appearance on which date, you are required to appear before the above Hon'ble Commission either in person or through your Advocate at **10.30 A.M.**, failing which you will be set ex parte and the matter will be decided in your absence on merits.

(BY ORDER)

SRIINVAS AJJARAPU, P. PRADEEP & A. V. H. S. RANJAN, ADVOCATES, 29-2-39, Near District Court, Visakhapatnam

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large are hereby informed that below mentioned documents have been misplaced / lost:-

(1) Original Allotment Letter, Original Possession Letter dated 31-07-1985 issued by DDA in favour of Purnoham Lal Rehman (2) Original Regd General Power of Attorney, ATS and WILL dated 27-09-1996 executed by Purnoham Lal Rehman in favour Durga Datta. (3) Original Notarized General Power of Attorney, ATS and WILL dated 04-11-1996 executed by Durga Datta in favour Deen Dayal. (4) Original Regd General Power of Attorney, ATS and WILL dated 27-02-1997 executed by Deen Dayal in favour Satish Mittal (5) Original Notarized General Power of Attorney, ATS and WILL executed by Satish Mittal in favour Arun Kumar Gupta (6) Original Regd General Power of Attorney, ATS and WILL dated 06-02-2006 executed by Arun Kumar Gupta in favour Ajay Kumar Chaddha (7) Original Conveyance Deed Dated 08-10-2009 executed by P.O.I. Through DDA in favour Ajay Kumar Chaddha duly registered as Document No. 14468 Book No. I Volume No. 3502 Pages No. 138 to 139 SR – VII New Delhi. (8) Original Sale Deed dated 02-07-2010 executed by Ajay Kumar Chaddha in favour Kiran Chaddha duly registered as Document No. 11988 Book No. I Volume No. 3675 Pages No. 123 to 128 SR – VII New Delhi. in respect of Janta Flat No 34, Situated in PWD – 7, Sec-6, Rohini, New Delhi-65.

Accordingly, Police complaint has already been lodged on Dated 18.07.2022 at P.S. CRIME BRANCH, DELHI. L.R. No.80359/2026 and the same is under investigation.

MRS Kiran Chaddha claims to be the owner of the property and has agreed to sell the same to M/s S. S. ENTERPRISES. And now M/s S. S. ENTERPRISES has approached the KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK for loan against mortgage of above said property. If any person has found / information / possession / knowledge of above said missing original documents or has any claim/right/title of any kind over the above said property, then submit intimate within 15 days in writing to Vikas Shokeen, Advocate, H-20, BASMINT, BALI NAGAR, NEW DELHI -110015. Thereafter any kind of claim will not be acceptable.

PVR LAW ASSOCIATES
Vikas Shokeen

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THE HINDU *thehindu.businessline.*

FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR THE HINDU

Govt. Polytechnic for Women Sirsa
Walk-in-Interview

Walk-in-interview is to be held for empanelment of visiting faculty/ visiting instructor (as a stop-gap arrangement) in Technician X-Ray Technology, Medical Laboratory Technology (MLT) & Office Management and Computer Applications (OMCA). This engagement will be purely temporary and on an hourly basis. Remuneration will be paid in accordance with the guidelines of the Govt. of Haryana(Directorate of Technical Education Panchkula, Haryana). Candidate possessing qualification as per Haryana Govt. Service Rules may appear for a walk in interview at the office of the Principal. Candidates must bring their original academic documents along with a set of attested copies on the dates specified below:

Sr. No.	Branch/Subject	Date
01	Technician X-Ray Technology	13.08.2026
02	Medical Laboratory Technology (MLT)	13.08.2026
03	Office Management and Computer Applications (Stenography)	13.08.2026

Note:- Applications will be accepted at the institute office only till 10:30 AM

Principal
Govt. Polytechnic for Women
Sirsa
1115/11/590/2027/47851/199/7

TAMILNADU CIVIL SUPPLIES CORPORATION
Head Office, CMRL Depot, Admin Building,
Poonamalli High Road, Chennai - 600107
Ph No. (044) 26426773, E.mail ID : tnscs.tn@nic.in
CIN: U15137TN1972SGC006157

SHORT E-TENDER NOTICE

Short e-tender No: BS4 /016600/2026/TNCSC/26-27 Dt.05.08.2026

Online short e-tender is invited for the **" PURCHASE OF 7.260 Bales of 5 PLY JUTE TWINE (WEIGHING 185 Kg. NETT PER BALE as per specifications.**

Complete short e-tender document can be viewed and downloaded through <https://tntenders.gov.in/nicgep/app>

The bidders have to participate online bidding only with Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) of Class-II or Class-III

Last Date and Time for Online Submission : **21.08.2026 Upto 11.00 AM**

DIPR /2464 / TENDER / 2026 **Managing Director**

PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
CHIEF ENGINEER (PROJECT) DEPARTMENT

Online Sale of Tenders :- 06/08/2026 to 13/08/2026 upto 03:00 PM
Last date of submission of tenders :- 06/08/2026 to 13/08/2026 at 03:00 PM
Date of opening of Tenders :- 14/08/2026 at 03:00 PM

Sr No	Tender No	Name of Work	Total Project Cost incl. GST, Royalty and Testing charges (Rs.)	Tender Amount (Excluding GST, Royalty, Testing charges (Rs.)	GST (18%) Rs.	Royalty Rs.	Material Testing Charges Rs.	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) 0.50 %	Security Deposit (%)	Time Limit in Calendar months including monsoon	Cost of Tender Document Rs.	All the documents are attached to online tender	Tender Type	Contact Persons
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
1	Pmc/ Chief Eng. (Project)/ 37/2026	Construction of Railway over bridge (ROB-I, Gate No. 586) on the Pune-Miraj railway line at Ghorpadi- execution of the remaining works	7,58,24,738/-	6,29,11,773	1,13,24,119	4,31,141/-	11,57,705	7,58,300	31,91,237	4 Months (Including mansson)	17,879/-	YES	New Tender	Sonali Wanjari (Jr. Engineer) 8262038510

A. This tender will be implemented as per B-1 type
B. Detailed terms / conditions for the tendered works are mentioned in the tender set and the tender set for this work is published on the website www.mahatenders.gov.in.
C. Complete information about online tendering process is available at The Office of Chief Engineer (Projects), 3rd Floor, Main Building, Pune Municipal Corporation, Shivajinagar, Pune-05.
D. EMD amount will be accepted only through ECS / RTGS / NEFT facility.
E. It will be sole responsibility of the tenderer if the tender set is not downloaded or submitted at the last moment.

ADVT No: 3/514, Date: 05/08/2026

Sd/-
Executive Engineer (Projects)
Pune Municipal Corporation

Government of Tamil Nadu
ELECTRONICS CORPORATION
TAMIL NADU LIMITED - ANGADI

9th Floor, Sigapi Aachi Building, 18/3, Rukmani Lakshminipathi Road, Egmore, Chennai-600 008
<https://elcotangadi.tn.gov.in> [+91 44 2855 1234] tenders@elcotangadi.in

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Tender No. E-ANGADI-RC-IT02-2026-0014

ELCOT Angadi invites **"Rate Contract Tender for empanelment of vendors for supply, installation and commissioning of Bio-metric devices, SSL & DSC, Data card & Voice Sim, through ELCOT Angadi e-Commerce portal"**. For complete details, please visit www.tntenders.gov.in. Pre-bid meeting: **11.08.2026, 11:00 AM** at ELCOT Nandanam Office. Last date for submission of e-bids: **03.09.2026, 3 PM.** For queries: tenders@elcotangadi.in.

DIPR/2463/Tender/2026 **GENERAL MANAGER (PROCUREMENT)**

Mission Vatsalya
District Child Protection Unit, Panchkula
Women & Child Development Department, Haryana
Room no-14, 1st Floor, New mini secretariat Sector-1, Panchkula

In Continuous of Advertisement published on dated 05/11/2024 12/2/2026 & 19.3.26 at various newspapers the Department has again invites applications for engaging of **8 Persons (Reserve 6 for Female and 2 for Male)** for empanelment of support Persons. Interested Persons can submit their application with their eligibility.

QUALIFICATION FOR SUPPORT PERSON:

Any person with a post graduate degree in Social Work or Sociology or Psychology or Child Development OR a graduate with minimum three years of experience in child education and development or protection issues.

Provided that in accordance with Rule 5(6) of the POCSSO Rules 2020, an entity qualified to act as a Support Person may also include an organization actively engaged in the realm of child rights or child protection. Additionally, an official associated with a children's home or shelter home responsible for the custody of the child may also be eligible to apply as a Support Person.

Interested Candidates may submit their application form in the office of District Child Protection Unit, Room no-14, 1st Floor, New mini secretariat Sector-1, Panchkula through registered post before **31, August 2026 before 5:00 PM** with all relevant documents self attested copy.

REMUNERATION OF SERVICES OF SUPPORT PERSONS:

a) Monthly Allowance: Any support person engaged for the purpose of assisting a child under POCSSO Act, shall be paid on a pro-rata basis, determined by the number of days worked or in-person visits conducted to locations such as Hospitals, Child Welfare Committee, police station, child Care Institutions, the victim's family, educational institution, court, government department, banks, etc. The Monthly remuneration Rs 600/- per day as per the amount prescribed for a high skilled worker under the Minimum Wages Act, 1948 (11 of 1948). Further, if a person empanelled as a support person has not been assigned any case or has not been providing support to a child, he/she shall not be entitled to claim remuneration.

b) Travel Allowance: The support person shall be provided reimbursement as per actual normal bus/Train fare or Rs 9/- per Kilometer for journey by own vehicle/private taxi/ vehicle but maximum 25 km/ in a day on for the travel undertaken with the minor victim on production of bills duly verified by Child Welfare Committee.

c) He/she can do multiple visits per day but wages will be availed per day and maximum wages for 20 days can be given.

Note:-

1. The empanelment of Support Person is not on a regular basis against any post, but is an empanelment initially for a period of three years to be reviewed by district Child Protection Officer and may be extended beyond three years on yearly basis by the recommendation of selection committee. If the support person does not report on time or does wrong reporting then he/she can be removed at any time without any notice during the tenure. The candidates shall have no right to claim for continuation or for regular employment in the Support Person as the appointment is only on honorarium paid basis. The decision of the selection Committee with regards to the eligibility of a candidate shall be final.

2. The age criteria for all the posts mentioned as above is 25-42 years.

3. The Eligibility of the candidate with regards to age, educational qualifications, experience etc, shall be determined on the date fixed for Document Verification of candidates of all the posts. The certificates issued after the date fixed for Document Verification will not be accepted by the committee.

4. All applicants must fulfil the essential requirements of the post and other conditions stipulated in the advertisement on the specified date of Document Verification. They are advised to satisfy themselves before applying that they possess at least the essential qualifications laid down for various posts. No enquiry asking for advice regarding eligibility will be entertained.

5. Each candidate needs to submit affidavit with the following point:

- He/she does not have any previous conviction record.
- He/ She have not been involved in any immoral Act or in child abuse or employment of Child Labour.
- No enquiry is pending against Him/her in any agency/Court
- The applicants have not any past record of violation of child rights or human rights.
- He must have domicile of Haryana.
- He must be resident of concerned applied District.

6. The prescribed essential qualifications are the minimum and mere possession of the same does not entitle candidates to be called for interview.

7. Interested candidate will be download Performa mentioned as District Child protection Unit from the given link <https://wcdhy.gov.in>

Sd/-
For Deputy Commissioner
Panchkula

1128/11/692/2027/47887/199/7

TAMILNADU CEMENTS CORPORATION LIMITED
(A GOVERNMENT OF TAMILNADU UNDERTAKING)
5th Floor, Avin Ilam, No.3A, Pasupam Muthuramalingam Salai, Nandanam, Chennai-600 035.

e- Tender Notice

e-Tender Ref. No.	Name of the Works	Est.value in Rs.	EMD in Rs.	Due Date
08/2026-27	Appointment of transport contractors for movement of packed cement through open trucks from Anyur Cement Works, Anyurur District to various destinations in Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala on rate contract basis.	44.94 crore	50,000	07.09.2026
09/2026-27	Appointment of transport contractors for movement of packed cement through open trucks from Angulgam Cement Works, Visakhapatnam District to various destinations in Tamil Nadu and Kerala on rate contract basis.	5.38 crore	50,000	07.09.2026

Important Note: Pre-bid meetings for a T.N.C. 08 & 09/2026-27 will be held on 13.08.2026 at 3.00 & 3.30 PM respectively at TANCEM, Registered Office, 5th Floor, Avin Ilam, No.3A, Pasupam Muthuramalingam Salai, Nandanam, Chennai-600 035. The Tender document can be downloaded from <https://tntenders.gov.in>. Consequent Addendum to this publication, if any would appear only on the above said website. DIPR/2454/TENDER/2026 **General Manager Marketing / DRO**

THE HINDU
DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

INBRIEF



Kushwaha's Minister son nominated as MLC in Bihar

Bihar Governor Lt. Gen. (retd.) Syed Ata Hasnain on Wednesday nominated Deepak Prakash to the Bihar Legislative Council to fill the vacancy arising from the resignation another nominated member, Devesh Kumar, on July 31. Mr. Prakash, 36, the son of Rashtriya Lok Morcha president Upendra Kushwaha, has up until now been the State's Panchayati Raj Minister since November 20, 2025, without being a member of either House of the State legislature. On July 30, the Supreme Court had rapped the Bihar government, asking how an unelected Minister [Deepak Prakash] could be kept even after six months.

Non-dairy paneer ban in Maharashtra and Gujarat

Maharashtra and Gujarat governments on Wednesday imposed a ban on production, distribution and sale of 'analogue' or non-dairy paneer. The action was taken after paneer samples were collected from various districts of the two States and analysed at notified food laboratories. The results made it clear that analogue paneer was being made from unauthorised and sub-standard ingredients and was being sold in growing numbers under the garb of dairy-based paneer. The ban has been imposed under the provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.

Vijay govt.'s debut budget strikes a balance between welfare, fiscal prudence

While some schemes based on the TVK's election promises found a place in the budget, several prominent assurances such as six free LPG cylinders a year for every family did not figure in it

B. Kolappan
N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's Tamila-ga Vetttri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government in Tamil Nadu presented its debut budget on Wednesday seeking to strike a balance between fiscal prudence and welfare and focusing on the empowerment of women, youth, students, and the elderly. While some schemes based on the TVK's election promises found a place in the budget, several prominent assurances such as monthly assistance of ₹2,500 for eligible women heads of families, six free LPG cylinders a year for every family, and free travel for women on all government buses did not figure in it. The budget, presented by Finance Minister N. Marie Wilson, also prioritised skill development and rural and infrastructure development. It proposed



Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay with Finance Minister N. Marie Wilson ahead of the budget presentation in Chennai on Wednesday. ANI

substantial allocations for several ongoing schemes while rebranding some other schemes and enhancing their allocations. **Outstanding debt** Mr. Wilson said the State's outstanding debt has been pegged at ₹10.98 lakh crore in the revised budget estimates for 2026-27. The outstanding debt-to-GSDP ratio is estimated at 27.01%. The government plans to

ship and the 'Annan's Seer' scheme, under which eligible brides will receive an eight-gram gold coin and a silk sari. The budget also announced the 'Vetri 150' initiative to provide additional 25 days of work to households upon completion of 125 days of work under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin). **AI city proposal** The budget also proposed to establish Arivagam, labelled as India's first AI and Innovation City; the Tamil Nadu Student Housing and Infrastructure Corporation to build 200 integrated student hostels with one lakh beds; Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Schools of Excellence with residential facilities; industry-aligned skill development for 12 lakh college students and one lakh unemployed youth; and declare Tirunelveli and Thoothukudi districts as space industrial investment zones in the State. borrow ₹1,73,445 crore and repay ₹51,971 crore this fiscal. The State's Own Tax Revenue is projected to grow by 9.78%, with commercial taxes accounting for 68.9% of the collections, followed by Stamps and Registration (15.5%) and State Excise (6.2%). Among the key announcements for women were the 'Singappengal Valimaippaduthum Thittam' to promote entrepreneur-

M.P. Speaker tenders apology for remarks on OBC community

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL



Narendra Singh Tomar

Madhya Pradesh Assembly Speaker Narendra Singh Tomar has issued an apology over his recent alleged offensive remarks on the Kushwaha community. In a letter addressed to the community, Mr. Tomar expressed regret and said he made the remarks at a family event. The move is being seen as an attempt at damage control following the BJP's defeat in the Datia Assembly bypoll. Political observers believe that the OBC community may have sided with the Congress. Addressing a gathering at the house of BJP's Morena district chief Kamlesh Kushwaha on July 31, Mr. Tomar had said the community occasionally "gula-ti khata raha (switched loyalty)" and "apni vishwasniyata ko khandit kiya (tarnished its credibility)". A purported video of the remarks went viral on social media, resulting in a backlash from the community. The Opposition Congress also criticised Mr. Tomar's remarks while terming them an insult to all OBC communities. The Kushwaha community is considered

among the strongest OBC groups in terms of the State's population and holds political significance in various regions, including the Gwalior-Chambal region, where both Morena and Datia fall. "I have respected the Kushwaha community all my life and will continue to do so. I cannot even imagine insulting it. If any of my words have hurt any member of the community, I withdraw those words and express regret for the pain caused," the letter, dated August 4, stated. **Courtesy call** Meanwhile, former Home Minister Narottam Mishra called on Ashutosh Tiwari, who was picked over him as the BJP's candidate for the Datia bypoll, and denied speculations hinting at a feud between the two.

'PDA' includes Pandits too, says Akhilesh in bid to woo Brahmins in Uttar Pradesh

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav at Janeshwar Mishra's birth anniversary celebrations at the party office in Lucknow on Wednesday. ANI

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Wednesday sought to expand his party's 'PDA' constituency and include Pandits or Brahmins in its Pichhda-Dalit-Alpsankhyak (Backwards, Dalits and minorities) matrix ahead of the State Assembly poll due early next year. The SP has used the PDA plank as a call for broader unity of forces of social justice since the 2022 Assembly election. "People keep talking about PDA and inventing new meanings about it. Ever since they (BJP) lost to PDA, they have been trying to redefine it. But they have forgotten that the 'PD' in PDA also stands for Pandit. The more they inflict *peeda* (pain), the stronger PDA will become," said the SP chief while addressing a 'Brahmin/Prabuddh varg Sammelan' at the party headquarters in Lucknow

on the birth anniversary of late Socialist leader and MP Janeshwar Mishra. Mr. Yadav hit out at the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh for "neglecting" Brahmins, other marginalised communities and religious leaders, and accused it of targeting Opposition workers and leaders. "They were already targeting our workers and us. Now they have also started targeting the Brahmin community. They are after the 'P' of PDA as well," he

alleged. The SP chief referred to Swami Avimukteshwaranand being prevented from taking a holy dip during the Kumbh congregation earlier this year. "If there is any example in history where a government stopped a Shankaracharya from taking a holy dip, show us one. A false POC-SO case was also filed to intimidate him, but he did not bow down," he said. In another signal to Brahmins, he said the SP,

whenever it has got the chance, has done the work of giving respect to the community. He touched upon the embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple as well: "Today, the biggest sin committed by anyone is that by the Bharatiya Janata Party, which stole even the offerings made to Lord Shri Ram... Lord Shri Ram will not let them win." **'Game changer'** Lucknow-based political analyst Asad Rizvi said the signal to Brahmins is aimed at securing a section of votes that could prove to be a game changer. "Brahmins, with a population of over 9%, are traditional BJP voters. The SP plans to align with the Brahmin community through Janeshwar Mishra's birth anniversary. It knows that winning the community's trust will significantly ease its path to power," he said.

Services hit as Maharashtra doctors launch protest over registration of homoeopaths

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI



Doctors protesting against the decision to allow homoeopaths to prescribe allopathic medicines, in Mumbai on Wednesday. ANI

The Maharashtra Association of Resident Doctors (MARD) launched an indefinite strike on Wednesday over the State government's decision to allow homoeopathy practitioners with a Certificate Course in Modern Pharmacology (CCMP) to register under the Maharashtra Medical Council (MMC). The strike affected outpatient department services in medical colleges associated with the MARD across the State and those run by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation. The issue flared up after a government resolution was issued on Monday permitting homoeopaths in the State to prescribe modern medicine. The first registration under the MMC was done later that day.

"The move compromises established medical education standards, professional integrity, and patient safety," MARD president at KEM Hospital Dr. Shubham Solanke said. **24-hour ultimatum** The MARD warned that if the registration process for CCMP-qualified Bachelor of Homoeopathic Medicine and Surgery practitioners is not halted within the

next 24 hours, it will intensify the stir and escalate the withdrawal of services. It asked the government to wait for the High Court's final judgment in the matter. The row erupted after the government amended the Maharashtra Homoeopathic Practitioners' Act and the Maharashtra Medical Council Act in 2014. The Indian Medical Association then challenged the changes in the High Court.

Kerala govt. to give ₹8 lakh to families of flood victims

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Cabinet on Wednesday announced ₹8 lakh each as financial assistance to the kin of those killed in the torrential rainfall and floods that ravaged large parts of the State over the past week. The death toll has risen to 26 even as four people are still missing, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan told a post-Cabinet briefing in Thiruvananthapuram. Across districts, 27,048 people are lodged at 462 relief camps. The highest number of camps are in Pathanamthitta (157), Kottayam (154) and Alappuzha (81) districts. **Compensation hiked** As part of the relief measures, the Cabinet decided to increase the compensation for 'fully damaged' houses from ₹4 lakh to ₹6 lakh and that for loss of both land and house, from ₹10 lakh to ₹12 lakh. Of the ₹8 lakh announced to kin of the deceased, ₹4 lakh will be drawn from the State Disaster Response Fund and ₹2 lakh each from the Chief Minister's Distress Relief Fund and the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund. Mr. Satheesan on Wednesday said the government had begun work on creating an "effective" long-term disaster resilience programme for the State. Announced in the United Democratic Front government's Revised Budget for 2026-27, the Kerala Disaster Resilience Programme will "serve as a model for the country," he added. A preliminary assessment has pegged losses to the State's farm sector at ₹67.44 crore. Crop damage has been reported in 1,882 hectares, affecting 23,537 farmers, the Chief Minister said, adding that the losses are likely to be slightly higher when the final figures are out.

Taslima Nasrin's return to Kolkata: politics behind the feted 'homecoming'

NEWS ANALYSIS

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA



The Suwendu Adhikari govt. has projected Taslima Nasrin's return to Kolkata after 19 years as one of its biggest achievements. FILE PHOTO

It does not happen often that posters are put up in the city to welcome a writer who has been away for almost two decades. But Kolkata, unlike other cities, can go to great lengths to honour its artists and writers. The city, depending on the politics of the day, can also drive writers out, as it did to Taslima Nasrin in the autumn of 2007. Her six-day visit to Kolkata was no less a political phenomenon than the violence that forced her out 19 years ago. Not only were posters put up celebrating her return, but the Chief Minister – Suwendu Adhikari – of the newly elected BJP government in West

Bengal shared the dais with her. For the Chief Minister and the BJP leadership in Bengal, Ms. Nasrin's visit was an opportunity to showcase a change from the earlier order. Mr. Adhikari, who has been in power for less than three months, indicated that the visit marked an improvement in law and order and

his government's refusal to let Muslim fundamentalist groups dictate terms. "It is not just the face of the government that has changed in West Bengal, the system too has changed," the Chief Minister said with Ms. Nasrin by his side. He promised security to the writer and said she could visit the city

whenever she liked. Reciprocating the gesture, she said at the end of her visit on Wednesday that she would visit Kolkata "whenever it calls me". **Support for UCC** Soon after her arrival on July 31, the exiled Bangladeshi writer thanked the BJP leadership for facilitating her return to Kolkata. She said the city was the closest place to her home in Bangladesh, which she had to flee in 1994. Asked about her views on the different governments in the State, she said, "One government had forced me out, another did not allow me to return, and one has helped me return." The writer did not stop at highlighting the treatment meted out to her by the governments led by the Left Front, Trinamool Congress and BJP. She called

for the implementation of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) and the banning of madrasas, issues that are being aggressively pursued by the BJP government. Ms. Nasrin's visit was thus not just a homecoming but a political event. The Suwendu administration, which is in a hurry to change the earlier political order, highlighted her return as one of its biggest achievements; a correction of the "failure" of the previous dispensations to defend free speech in the face of religious pressure. The Left parties and the Trinamool Congress did not have much to say on why the writer couldn't return to Kolkata for so many years. Both regimes surrendered to the whims of Muslim fundamentalist groups and believed that her return could dent their Muslim support base.

The failure of the "secular forces" to allow Ms. Nasrin to return stemmed from selective appeasement and the prioritisation of vote-bank politics over free expression. The BJP, which came to power after polarising Hindu votes, used the visit to suggest that the government would not bend to such pressure. In fact, it would go the extra mile to do the very opposite. **'Imprisoning future'** Speaking at an event in Kolkata on August 1, Ms. Nasrin cited the example of Bangladesh and said that when the state bows to religious fanatics, violence can be averted for a brief period of time. However, the peace purchased so does not last long. "A society which kills its critic or imprisons and sends them to exile does not kill the

critic alone but kills, imprisons and sends its future to exile," she said. Her return did not impact the politics of Bengal alone. It may also have cast a shadow on India-Bangladesh relations, which were under considerable strain after the fall of Sheikh Hasina's regime in August 2024. Not to mention the irony of the Suwendu government, which has publicly spoken on driving every Bangladeshi out of the State, welcoming a Bangladeshi author in exile to polish its image on law and order, freedom of speech and rights of minorities. Yet, on the question of freedom of speech and rights of minorities, the most glaring violations in the State today are happening under the drive to push men and women into Bangladesh only on suspicion of their being foreigners.



विकसित भारत - समृद्ध बिहार

श्री सम्राट चौधरी

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

के कर-कमलों द्वारा

बिहार संग्रहालय स्थापना दिवस 2026 समारोह का उद्घाटन

विशिष्ट अतिथि

श्री विजय कुमार चौधरी

माननीय उप मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

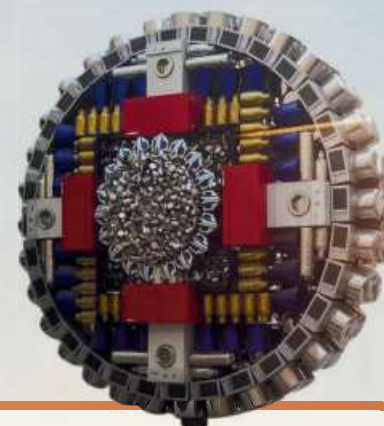
श्री बिजेन्द्र प्रसाद यादव

माननीय उप मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

अध्यक्षता

डॉ. प्रमोद कुमार

माननीय मंत्री, कला एवं संस्कृति विभाग, बिहार



इतिहास, कला एवं संस्कृति के विविध आयामों का भव्य उत्सव

समारोह का उद्घाटन

7 अगस्त 2026

संध्या 4:00 बजे

बिहार संग्रहालय

मिथिला की कालजयी चित्रकला (प्रदर्शनी)

7 अगस्त 2026

संध्या 4:00 बजे

पटना संग्रहालय

लोककला पर आधारित बिहार संग्रहालय
बिनाले - 2027 पर संगोष्ठी

8 अगस्त 2026

पूर्वाह्न 11:00 - 1:30 बजे

बिहार संग्रहालय

भारत के कालजयी
कलाकार (प्रदर्शनी)

7 अगस्त 2026

संध्या 4:00 बजे

अस्थायी दीर्घा, बिहार संग्रहालय

कागज की कश्ती - राजेश राम की प्रदर्शनी

7 अगस्त 2026

संध्या 4:00 बजे

बहुउद्देशीय दीर्घा, बिहार संग्रहालय

राजेश राम की कला पर परिचर्चा:
व्यक्तित्व एवं कृतित्व

8 अगस्त 2026

अपराह्न 3:00 - 5:00 बजे

बिहार संग्रहालय

सांस्कृतिक कार्यक्रम - राजस्थान के सुप्रसिद्ध कालबेलिया नृत्य, चरी नृत्य एवं मंगणियार गायन की प्रस्तुति

7, 8 एवं 9 अगस्त 2026

संध्या 6:30 बजे

बिहार संग्रहालय

सौजन्य: पश्चिम क्षेत्र सांस्कृतिक केन्द्र, उदयपुर, राजस्थान



दिनांक
7 अगस्त, 2026



समय
4:00 बजे अपराह्न



स्थान
बिहार संग्रहालय नेहरू पथ, पटना



Highs and lows

GST must be fuelled by domestic production, not inflation or imports

That GST grossed ₹2.11 lakh crore in July, expanding by 15.4% year-on-year, the second best growth in FY27, could indicate that the Indian economy is resilient. But it conceals the uneven internal and external trajectories, and disparities within India. The 26.9% growth in import IGST *vis-à-vis* a 4.5% rise in domestic revenues ferrets out the criticality in the trade-led tax buoyancy. IGST's faster pickup started during the post-pandemic recovery, reflective of global commodity inflation, higher imports of capital goods and the rupee's depreciation. A 10%-12% depreciation of the Indian denomination over the past year had its reflection on the rupee cost of crude oil, electronics, machinery and chemicals – they collectively constitute as much as 50% of total imports – contributing to a higher import bill. Although gold imports added to higher IGST collections, supply fell to a six-year low, due to lower bullion imports, which fell 22%. High WPI inflation, notably at the manufacturing level, at 7.18% this June against 1.52% a year-ago period, explains the traction of domestic revenues in an ad valorem tax system amid five-year low manufacturing growth as seen from the HSBC Manufacturing PMI. The services witnessed slowest growth in 53 months with real estate and business services recording the strongest rise in charges, but the sector's GST buoyancy is concentrated geographically.

The fiscal reality is that only 16 States/UTs have reported post-settlement GST growth exceeding the national average and a little over a dozen States saw higher than average growth in GST, showing an increasingly chequered path as manufacturing and organised services are concentrated in a few jurisdictions; others, especially those with a larger unorganised sector, struggle to generate tax buoyancy, becoming dependent on central transfers and Finance Commission devolution. GST 3.0 should ensure that the benefits of economic expansion are geographically broad-based and fiscally inclusive. The faster domestic refunds, in comparison to IGST refunds, imply that formal businesses are expanding their GST compliance and also carrying larger credit balances as the government improved the GST ecosystem, even as faultlines such as input tax credit disputes and litigation are yet to be resolved. The July numbers warrant a closer reading as a healthy GST trajectory should reflect domestic production, growing incomes and broad-based consumption rather than exchange-rate-induced gains in import taxation and piggyback riding on local inflation. Otherwise 'Make in India' remains a tall claim as imported inputs do much of the heavy lifting in the GST metrics.

Quantum shift

Private R&D spends should be used to bolster manufacturing

The Department of Science and Technology's latest figures on India's research profile record a milestone. In 2023-24, private industry accounted for 51.8% of national research spending – a first in India's history – overtaking all tiers of government combined for the first time. Moreover, industry now employs more core researchers than government institutions. Transport firms are the largest corporate investors, followed by pharmaceuticals, biotechnology and information technology (IT). The break from the past is sharp. Through the 2010s, private industry contributed a little over a third of national R&D, and the ratio moved slowly. Then, between 2020-21 and 2021-22, private spending nearly doubled – from ₹46,388 crore to ₹82,975 crore – and total R&D jumped from ₹1.27 lakh crore to ₹1.95 lakh crore in a single year. R&D spends in the transport sector, which barely registered before 2020, has roughly tripled and leads the triumvirate that includes biotechnology and IT that are counted among India's most research-intensive industries.

Officials attribute this to a post-pandemic realisation that research is essential to competitiveness, and that may be part of the story. The purported investments for '23-'25 also look healthy, but a change concentrated in one year looks less like a shift in corporate behaviour and more like a change in what is counted. Mandatory sustainability disclosures for large listed firms, and tighter RBI norms on reporting research, took effect at the same moment. Spending that was always occurring – in the foreign subsidiaries of Indian companies, and in the captive centres of multinationals – is only now being fully captured. Some of the surge, in other words, reflects better measurement rather than more money. Genuinely new capital is flowing too – into artificial intelligence, chip design and semiconductor fabs – though much of that is still infrastructure building and may not yet belong in the R&D column. India's R&D stands at 0.84% of GDP, against 2.58% for China, 3.45% for the U.S. and 4.94% for South Korea; it fields 354 researchers per million people where South Korea and Israel field several thousand. The private sector's own priorities are a further reason for caution: more was spent on advertising than on research in 2023-24. The shift will prove worthwhile if it deepens India's pool of specialised workers and its capacity for sophisticated manufacturing, carrying the economy beyond its long reliance on supplying low-cost services. That depends less on how spending is recorded than on how many researchers the country can train. The Anusandhan National Research Foundation, with a ₹50,000-crore corpus largely to be raised from private sources, was created for precisely this purpose. Its promise now rests on delivery.

The Finance Commission, an institutional innovation embedded in India's constitutional architecture, was never intended to be a routine allocator of funds. It was designed as a central pillar of India's fiscal federal compact and as a corrective institution that would mediate the inherent asymmetry between a fiscally dominant Union and structurally constrained States, while also addressing deep horizontal inequalities arising from history, geography, and institutional capacity. In a country marked by uneven development at Independence, the Commission's central mandate was to safeguard the interests of the States and thereby preserve a strong Union.

Each successive Commission, cognisant of its historical context, has interpreted this mandate in its own way, yet all have contributed to sustaining India's fiscal federal compact. The recently submitted report of the 16th Finance Commission (FC-16), chaired by Arvind Panagariya and covering the period 2026-31, marks a decisive turning point. While it retains the vertical devolution of central taxes to the States at 41%, it fundamentally re-engineers the structure of fiscal transfers, particularly grants-in-aid. In doing so, it prioritises efficiency and performance but raises serious concerns about equity and constitutional intent. At the heart of the issue lies a deeper question: has the Commission moved away from its equalising role toward one that implicitly protects the Union's fiscal primacy?

The constitutional logic of grants-in-aid Evidently, the provision for grants-in-aid under Article 275 was not an afterthought; it was a foundational design element. In a country more diverse than any other in the world, tax devolution, however sophisticated its formula, cannot account for the diversity of State-specific needs. For instance, Kerala's "export-oriented" human capital development strategy has accounted for nearly 23% of India's total remittances, thereby strengthening the country's external sector. However, this has come at a cost to the State's fiscal health, as it has had to rely on borrowing to finance investments in education.

Similarly, Punjab has played a critical role in ensuring national food security, but at the cost of its revenue base, by focusing on the production of wheat and rice, which are non-taxable apart from paying the price of being a border State. The same is true of the hill States, which face high infrastructure costs; the north-eastern States, which grapple with connectivity constraints; and fiscally stressed States burdened by demographic pressures and social sector commitments.

Grants-in-aid were therefore conceived as instruments of equalisation, enabling targeted support for States with special needs where formula-based tax devolution falls short. The F-14



K.J. Joseph

Director, Gulati Institute of Finance and Taxation, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala



Sumalatha B.S.

Assistant Professor, Gulati Institute of Finance and Taxation, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala

The Sixteenth Finance Commission risks moving away from its core mandate of acting as an equalising force within the federation

and the FC-15 recognised this reality by retaining Revenue Deficit Grants (RDGs), sector-specific grants, and State-specific grants.

The FC-16 departs sharply from this tradition. It recommends grants-in-aid of ₹9.47 lakh crore, compared with ₹10.1 lakh crore under the FC-15, while their share in total Finance Commission transfers has more than halved, from 19.4% to 8.3%. By restricting grants-in-aid to local bodies and disaster management, it eliminates RDGs, sector-specific grants, and State-specific grants.

While retaining the States' share in the divisible pool at 41%, despite the demand from 18 States to raise it to 50%, the Commission presumes that improved fiscal discipline should enable States to manage their finances without additional gap-filling transfers. However, this reasoning rests on a problematic assumption: that fiscal capacity across States is sufficiently uniform for devolution to be self-equalising.

Empirically and historically, this assumption is untenable. The Commission's justification for doing away with RDGs is rooted in concerns about fiscal prudence. It argues that RDGs create moral hazard by incentivising States to underperform in revenue mobilisation or overspend in the expectation of central support.

It also points to aggregate data suggesting that the States, taken as a whole, are not in severe fiscal distress. Yet, this aggregate view masks deep inter-State disparities, with some States remaining fiscally stressed despite contributing disproportionately to national development and continuing to require fiscal assistance. The very purpose of RDGs was to recognise this heterogeneity, as a fiscal surplus in one State cannot offset a fiscal deficit in another.

More troubling is the contrast between the Commission's stance on RDGs and its treatment of cesses and surcharges. While advocating fiscal discipline for States through the withdrawal of RDGs, it stops short of recommending any binding rollback of these non-shareable union levies ignoring the demand by many States.

Dual shift

Instead, it proposes a "grand bargain", whereby the Centre would gradually merge cesses into the divisible pool in exchange for States accepting a lower devolution share. This asymmetry is difficult to overlook. RDGs are removed in the name of discipline, yet cesses – arguably a more distortionary instrument from a federal perspective – are only gently nudged toward reform. The resulting framework imposes stringency on States while preserving fiscal flexibility for the Union. This dual shift, protecting Union revenues while constraining State support, raises a fundamental concern: is the Commission inadvertently reinforcing vertical imbalance rather than correcting it?

The consequences are particularly severe for

States that already face structural disadvantages. As many as eight States, including most of the disadvantaged north-eastern States and fiscally stressed West Bengal, are set to experience a reduced share in both tax devolution and grants-in-aid, while another six States have seen a decline in their share of grants. The problem is further compounded by the reduction in the weight assigned to income distance (from 45% to 42.5%) and the introduction of a 10% weight for contribution to GDP. When combined with the removal of the RDGs, which accounted for about 20% of Finance Commission grants in 2024-25, this creates a double burden: lower tax devolution and the absence of compensatory grants. The Commission's implicit assumption that efficiency should trump equity risks widening regional disparities.

Another defining feature of the FC-16 is its emphasis on tied and performance-based grants, particularly for local governments. While the allocation of nearly ₹7.2 lakh crore to the third tier is commendable, the conditionalities attached to these grants are stringent, linking the release of funds to targets in water and sanitation, revenue mobilisation, and audited accounts. This approach promotes accountability, but it also reduces fiscal autonomy. In effect, the architecture of grants shifts from need-based equalisation to compliance-based incentivisation. Fiscal discipline, while necessary, cannot substitute for fiscal justice.

Efficiency versus equity

The FC-16's report is bold in ambition but uneven in balance. The dismantling of the RDGs and the shift toward performance-based transfers reflect a technocratic confidence in market-like incentives, even though fiscal federalism is a political and constitutional arrangement designed to manage diversity. The contrast between the Commission's strict stance on RDGs and its accommodative approach to cesses and surcharges, along with its hesitation to raise the States' share in the divisible pool to 50% despite demands from several States, reveals a deeper tension.

It suggests a framework that, intentionally or otherwise, protects the fiscal space of the Union while placing a greater adjustment burden on the States. In doing so, the Commission may have moved away from its core mandate of acting as an equalising force within the federation. If the Finance Commission is to continue playing its historic role in holding India together, future Commissions must reward high-performing States while supporting those that continue to face structural disadvantages.

For a country as diverse as India, fiscal federalism cannot be sustained on performance alone; it must be anchored in fairness.

The views expressed are personal

A climate resilience pathway between India and China

This year, El Niño delayed the monsoon in India. When the rains arrived, they were intense, with cities such as Mumbai and Surat receiving a month's rainfall in a matter of days. Regions in Assam and Odisha have experienced severe flooding, resulting in loss of life and damage to infrastructure. Similar conditions have recently affected large swathes of China's provinces, particularly Guangxi, Shaanxi and Gansu. Such extreme weather events are becoming increasingly common, threatening economic growth, food security, and public well-being in the two most populous countries.

In both cases, experts attribute these short, high-intensity bursts to climate change which is causing higher atmospheric temperatures and rapidly warming oceans. Mitigating and recovering from these frequent and large-scale events will become increasingly important for China and India to address. Given the scale of the challenge, could climate resilience become an opening for India-China cooperation?

Similar climate extremes

India and China confront remarkably similar challenges. Rapid urbanisation has replaced wetlands, forests, and permeable surfaces with concrete. Changing weather patterns, combined with outdated drainage systems, poor waste management, rapid urbanisation, and a lack of green spaces, have aggravated waterlogging and flooding. Coastal megacities face the combined risks of extreme precipitation, storm surges, and sea-level rise, while inland cities grapple with heatwaves, droughts, and flash floods occurring in quick succession. These challenges demand scientific collaboration, technological innovation, stronger local governance, and community participation. The costs of inaction include disrupted supply chains, economic losses, declining productivity, and mounting public health risks. This may be the right moment for renewed engagement between India and China. After years of strained ties, bilateral relations are showing tentative and slow signs of improvement.



Shruti Jargad

Non-Resident Research Associate at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP)



Pooja Ramamurthy

Fellow at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP)

Shared climate challenges create opportunities for India-China cooperation

In April 2026, the visit by a Chinese delegation led by China's Special Envoy for Climate Change to New Delhi suggests that climate cooperation remains a priority. Within the area of climate and clean energy, identifying key issues for engagement is important. Collaboration in areas such as green technology and critical minerals remains challenging due to economic competition and geopolitical tensions. Disaster mitigation and urban resilience could offer a relatively low-risk pathway for rebuilding trust.

Past engagement, sister city agreements

A mapping of India and China's climate engagement in a recent paper by the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP) shows that there is precedent for such engagement. Beginning from the early 1990s until 2020, there were several summit-level joint statements, agreements and Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) calling for practical cooperation on climate change. Topics included climate-induced disasters such as floods, earthquake, droughts and extreme weather events. These MoUs promised facilitation of joint research and development, hydrological, oceanic and seismic data sharing, and exchange of governance practices. During the six Strategic Economic Dialogues, policymakers discussed sustainable urban planning, waste management, sewage treatment, water efficiency and capacity building.

Practical implementation of joint projects in these areas was formally agreed upon in the multiple sister city agreements – Delhi-Beijing, Mumbai-Shanghai, and Chennai-Chongqing. Yet, disruptions in diplomatic engagement resulted in little on-ground action.

China demonstrates the importance of embedding resilience into core urban and rural planning investment decisions. This includes using data-driven approaches to drive policies in transport, housing and drainage systems. India's strength lies in adaptive governance, spearheading community-led strategies for targeted interventions in vulnerable populations.

Successes in India have been seen in early warning systems, heat action plans, cool roofs and nature-based solutions. There has to be engagement between state and non-state actors. Officials from municipal governments can enable knowledge and policy exchanges on urban design such as sponge cities, drainage modernisation and waste management.

Beyond urban issues, rural livelihoods and resilient agricultural practices for food security become salient points for mutual learning. Joint collaboration between planning agencies and academic institutions can improve systems for hydrological modelling and integrating regional and indigenous knowledge into climate adaptation strategies. A critical aspect will be addressing challenges of the melting glacial systems in the shared Himalayan ecosystem. While India and China had agreements on shared water resources, they ceased to function in 2022.

The finance gap

A major barrier to climate adaptation remains financing, with both countries relying heavily on public funds to carry out their policies. Bridging this gap requires greater private sector participation through tools such as blended finance, municipal bonds, and credit enhancement. However, these are nascent ecosystems, constrained by limited local capacity and regulatory gaps. Evidence-based studies and knowledge exchanges between India and China on these models could provide an innovative avenue for engagement. Such cooperation would not only benefit both countries but also enable them to shape climate resilience norms across the Global South through stronger standards, metrics, and fiscal frameworks.

Climate change impacts transcend national borders, from Europe's heatwaves to Asia's heavy monsoon floods. Greater coordination and cooperation could provide India and China with a pathway for a low-risk, win-win engagement.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Language in politics

Recent developments in political discourse across India, particularly in Tamil Nadu, underscore the need for restraint, dignity, and moderation in public debate. Language is the apparel of democracy. If democracy is the best form of governance, it must be

protected, nurtured, and enriched. The language used in public life reflects one's commitment to democratic values.

K.S.S. Seshan,
Errepalle, Andhra Pradesh

As a septuagenarian, I have witnessed many changes in our country over the

decades — some for the better, others for the worse. Among the latter, one of the most disturbing has been the steady decline in the quality of public discourse in recent years, particularly among our political leaders. With millions watching them every day on television and social media,

political leaders ought to realise that their words and conduct shape public behaviour. It is therefore unsurprising that coarse, intemperate, and abusive language has gradually become normalised in our society. Sharp exchanges between the treasury benches and

the Opposition are an integral part of any vibrant democracy. But when political discourse descends into vile personal attacks, drags family members into political battles, pries into private lives, or levels unsubstantiated allegations of moral turpitude, it demeans public life and

weakens democratic values. Those who sow the wind of abuse should not complain when they reap the whirlwind of retaliation.

G.P. Menon,
Tripunithura, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

India’s cancer focus must shift to early detection

Every day, oncology clinics across India confront the same heartbreaking reality. More than 70% of patients present with advanced-stage cancer, when treatment is more complex, more expensive, and far less likely to achieve a cure. Over the past two decades, India has invested substantially in building world-class tertiary cancer centres and has expanded access to sophisticated surgery, radiation therapy, and systemic treatments. Yet these advances cannot deliver their full potential because most patients arrive too late.

The solution to this challenge lies upstream. Cancer in India is still diagnosed predominantly after symptoms become severe enough to disrupt daily life. By then, opportunities for curative treatment have often been lost. The consequences extend far beyond health. More than three-quarters of cancer-affected households experience catastrophic healthcare expenditure. Late diagnosis is therefore not only a medical problem – it also drives poverty. Moreover, five-year survival for lung cancer in India is only about 4%, compared with nearly 33% in Japan. Similar gaps exist across several common cancers, reflecting differences not merely in treatment quality but in the stage at which patients enter the healthcare system. A delayed diagnosis is thus a poor outcome on all fronts.

Need for fundamental change The scale of the challenge continues to grow. India recorded an estimated 1.56 million new cancer cases and over 8,74,000 cancer deaths in 2024. The lifetime risk of developing cancer has now reached approximately 11% nationally and exceeds 20% in some northeastern States. As the population ages and lifestyles change, this burden will continue to rise unless our national strategy changes fundamentally.



Dr. Harit K. Chaturvedi

CEO & Clinical Head, Apollo Oncology Network

Cancer in India is still diagnosed predominantly after symptoms become severe enough to disrupt daily life. By then, opportunities for curative treatment have often been lost

The first step is to redefine prevention as a lifelong public health priority rather than as an occasional awareness campaign. Nearly half of all cancers are preventable. However, efforts to spread awareness among adults give poor results as lifestyle wiring happens at an early age. Once habits are coded, it is extremely difficult to course correct them through awareness campaigns. Health education must therefore begin in schools, where “life skills” should receive the same importance as other mainstream subjects such as mathematics or social sciences. These life skills would not only help in cancer prevention but also other major health issues such as cardiac, neurological, vascular, and bowel diseases. Such education would comprehensively cover all aspects related to physical, mental and social health, addictions, diet, vaccinations, financial literacy, and responsibilities towards the family, society, and nation.

The second step is the need to receive earlier diagnoses. Public awareness about the fact that persistent symptoms lasting more than three weeks deserve medical evaluation can substantially reduce diagnostic delays. However, symptom awareness alone is insufficient. Screening remains our most powerful tool for identifying cancer before symptoms appear. Until recently, organised screening was largely confined to cancers such as cervical, breast, and prostate cancer. Scientific advances are now expanding these possibilities. Blood-based Multi-Cancer Early Detection (MCED) tests have the potential to detect biological signals from multiple malignancies – including colorectal, lung, liver, pancreatic, ovarian, gastric, oesophageal, breast, prostate, and bladder cancers – through a single blood sample.

While these technologies still require careful evaluation for population-wide implementation, they represent one of the most promising frontiers in cancer

research and deserve focused Indian validation.

Future plan for India

India must also develop solutions suited to its own healthcare realities. A single centralised screening programme cannot effectively serve a country of 1.4 billion people with enormous geographical and socioeconomic diversity. Instead, we need a layered model combining community health workers, digital risk assessment, AI, mobile diagnostic services, and strong referral pathways linking primary care with cancer centres.

Encouragingly, important foundations are already being laid. NITI Aayog is supporting the development of a large imaging biobank comprising more than 20,000 cancer patient profiles. Such datasets can accelerate the development of AI tools capable of assisting frontline healthcare workers in identifying suspicious lesions and prioritising patients who require specialist evaluation.

The Draft National Health Research Policy 2026 provides an opportunity to accelerate this transformation. By prioritising diseases that contribute the most to India’s health burden and encouraging research with measurable impact, the policy signals a welcome shift from publication-driven research towards implementation science. This approach should encourage innovation in affordable screening technologies, risk prediction models, digital health platforms, and implementation research that improves cancer detection across India’s diverse healthcare settings.

India should not measure progress in cancer care solely by the sophistication of treatments delivered during advanced stages. The true measure of success is how many cancers never reach an advanced stage. And that success will require coordinated partnerships between government agencies, medical colleges, technology companies, and community healthcare providers.

YSRCP’s search for political momentum

The YSRCP chief is desperately trying to regain his foothold in Andhra politics

STATE OF PLAY

Sumit Bhattacharjee

Two years after suffering one of the most severe electoral setbacks in its history, the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) appears to be trying its best to breach the NDA (National Democratic Alliance) fortress and once again gain a strong-hold in Andhra politics. However, it has not been an easy task, primarily because, as political scientists point out, the YSRCP cadre base is in disarray, and has failed to capitalise on pertinent issues that could have become major rallying points against the Chandrababu Naidu-led NDA government.

However, in the last few months, YS Jagan Mohan Reddy, president of the YSRCP, has been hitting the road quite often after a hiatus of about a year following the election debacle, which could serve as a motivating factor for his party leaders and cadre.

Mobilising efforts

Mr. Reddy began his comeback trail by opposing the State Government’s proposal to develop at least 10 of the 17 medical colleges under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) mode. However, as per analysts, the YSRCP chief could only partially capitalise on the issue as the government, to a large extent, was successful in changing public opinion by arguing that the PPP mode would allow colleges to become operational faster without placing the entire financial burden on the State, whose finances had allegedly been weakened by the earlier YSRCP government. The NDA government has consistently maintained that private invest-



ment is essential for completing unfinished infrastructure projects, improving facilities, and expanding access to specialised healthcare services.

Additionally, with the success of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests in New Delhi, the YSRCP had been trying hard to scale up its protest over alleged irregularities in the District Selection Committee (DSC) recruitment, but has, so far, not been able to garner that kind of mass response or participation. The State government has rejected such allegations in the DSC recruitment process and insisted that the exercise was conducted fairly and transparently. The government not only countered every allegation with proof (or so it claims), it is also basking in the glory of successfully conducting the long-pending exam and recruiting close to 16,000 teachers.

Falling back on farmers

The 2024 election results have certainly dented the YSRCP’s image, but Mr. Reddy is known for his resilience. Of late, he has been working on highlighting the issues plaguing farmers, especially those related to minimum support prices and the alleged unfulfilled promises of the ruling coalition.

He began his campaign by engaging with farmers in February this year, when he visited chilli farmers at the Guntur Chilli Yard. He demanded

that the State Government work out a remunerative price and also flagged the sharp drop in chilli prices. Here again, the State government was quick to address the issue through a multi-pronged strategy involving market intervention, financial aid, acreage management, and strict quality control measures.

Farmers constitute a huge chunk of the electoral mandate and play a decisive role in election outcomes. Mr. Reddy’s father, Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, had also focused on farmers’ welfare, which catapulted him to power as Chief Minister of undivided Andhra in 2004. He is still regarded as the farmers’ Chief Minister.

Mr. Reddy’s every visit has been mired in some controversy, and at times the YSRCP has alleged police excesses. In almost every visit, there has been a scuffle with the police, including the one in Bangarupalem, where he had gone on July 9, 2025, to meet mango farmers, and in Srikakulam, where he had gone on July 30, 2026, to meet his former minister, Seediri Appalaraju. Some of his visits have also been controversial such as the recent one in which he visited Mr. Appalaraju. The former minister is in jail for allegedly screening evidence in an accident case involving his son. The NDA was quick to latch onto the issue and accused Mr. Reddy of visiting the accused while not caring to visit the family of the deceased.

In all this, the larger challenge before Mr. Reddy is to transform the current momentum into a lasting political advantage. Protests and demonstrations may generate immediate attention, but only a coherent policy alternative can sustain public confidence.

sumit.b@thehindu.co.in

Did abrogating special status for J&K make a difference?

Analysis of data show that the Union government has not delivered on its promise of wide-ranging transformation in Jammu and Kashmir

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Pon Vasanth B.A.
Sachin Swaraj

Seven years have passed since the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) introduced legislations in Parliament to implement its long-standing objective – stripping the special status accorded to the State of Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) by Article 370 of the Constitution. Through these legislations, the Union government not only abrogated the special status, but also took direct control of the State’s administration by bifurcating it into two Union Territories – J&K and Ladakh.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who introduced the legislations in both Houses, projected them as a panacea for J&K’s woes. Attributing the State’s poor healthcare, poverty and slow economic growth to the special status, he argued that Article 370 prevented J&K’s economic development while breeding terrorism.

On August 5, 2026, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a post on X, “Seven years ago, on this day, articles 370 and 35(A) became history, marking a decisive new chapter in the journey of Jammu and Kashmir as well as Ladakh.” He said lives had been transformed by growing opportunities in education, healthcare, entrepreneurship and sports.

An analysis of available data shows that while many of Mr. Shah’s 2019 contentions about J&K’s backwardness in health and education were misleading, the Union government has not delivered on its promise of wide-ranging transformation – be it in the economy, on terrorism or civil liberties. J&K was in fact a relatively better-performing State before 2019 on indicators such as life expectancy, poverty, infant mortality, government doctors per capita, and human development index.

Data gaps after the bifurcation make meaningful comparison difficult on several socio-economic indicators. For instance, the annual finance audit reports of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) note missing data in many sections.

Data shows that J&K’s economy contracted by 1% in real terms in 2019-20 and shrank further during the pandemic in 2020-21. It rebounded subsequently, partly on a low base, but growth dropped sharply in 2024-25 (**Chart 1**). Capital outlay for J&K, according to the CAG’s finance accounts reports, did not increase significantly and in fact contracted in the two years since 2019 (**Chart 2**).

On the education front, higher education enrolment in J&K and its Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) declined in 2022-23 and 2023-24 – the latest years for which All India Survey on Higher Education reports are available. The drop in enrolments was particularly sharp in 2023-24 (-11%) (**Chart 3**). The Periodic Labour Force Survey reports show that while the unemployment rate did not improve noticeably for men, it rose for women, particularly in 2023-24 (**Chart 4**). RBI data show that the number of factories in J&K dropped marginally between 2019-20 and 2023-24, though a Lok Sabha reply this week stated marginal improvements in the number of small companies and start-ups.

Though curbing terrorism was a key objective of the 2019 legislations, the number of incidents and deaths of civilians and soldiers have not dropped below 2012-2016 levels (**Chart 5**). Meanwhile, cases registered under the draconian Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act and the number of undertrials and detainees have increased sharply. J&K’s Freedom House score for civil liberties and political rights has also declined since 2019 (**Table 1**).

Importantly, the government’s promise of restoring J&K’s Statehood remains unfulfilled.

Undelivered promises

The data for the charts were sourced from the RBI, Freedom House, the NCRB, Software Freedom Law Center (SFLC) and South Asia Terrorism Portal. With inputs from Gandla Sneha and Nivedha M. The two and Sachin Swaraj interned with The Hindu

CHART 1: Gross State Domestic Product and rate of growth (in constant prices) for Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh over years

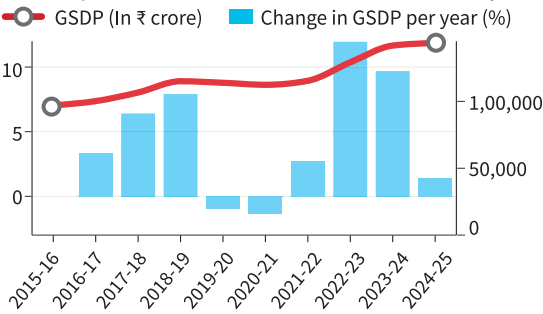


CHART 2: Capital outlay (in ₹ crore) and change in outlay per year (in %)

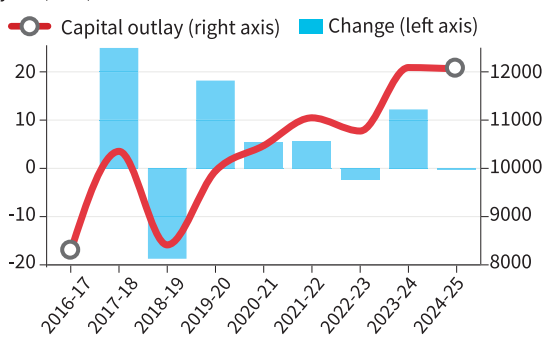


CHART 3: Total enrolments in higher education and Gross enrolment ratio (GER) for J&K and Ladakh

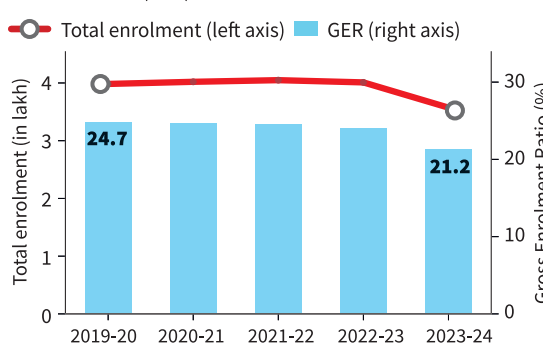


TABLE 1: Number of Internet shutdowns, undertrials, detainees and UAPA cases. Values not available for cells left blank

State/UT	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Internet shutdowns	10	32	65	55	116	79	43	14	3	12	4
Civil liberties		28	27	27	20	20	20	20	20	21	21
Political rights		22	22	22	8	7	7	7	6	17	17
UAPA cases	161	156	245	255	287	289	371	178	215		
No. of detainees	432	212	283	404	228	252	546	632	667		
No. of undertrials	1959	2181	2568	3075	3738	4547	4613	4610	4593		



CHART 4: Unemployment rate per thousand persons for Jammu and Kashmir

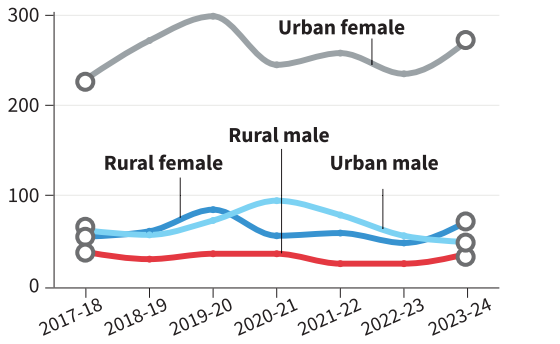
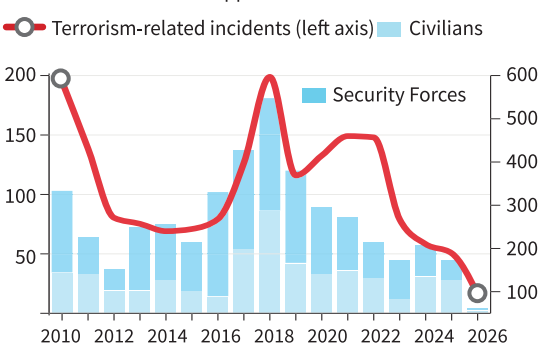


CHART 5: Terrorism-related incidents and deaths of civilians and soldiers have not dropped below 2012 to 2016 levels



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 6, 1976

More students fancy snuff

Madras, August 5: Snuff, a sniff of which is said to drive drowsiness away, is spreading its sway in the country.

A survey of the snuff industry in Madras, the biggest snuff production centre in the country, revealed, however that fashions and fads, like the ceremonious use of ornate snuff boxes that attended the advent of snuff, are passing away.

There were but a dozen manufacturers in the city till 40 years ago. Their number now exceeds 100 and production has gone up to 2,367 tonnes a year.

The city gets its raw material, tobacco, from Andhra Pradesh. Snuff is produced in Gujarat, Punjab, and Uttar Pradesh also, but they account for only a fraction of the country’s total production.

Snuff-users are predominantly villagers, especially along the coastal regions stretching in a great arc from Gujarat to West Bengal, the demand being the greatest along the Kerala coast. Mr. M.V. Ranga Rao, Secretary of the Madras State Snuff and Tobacco Merchants Association, says snuff has found growing patronage among students.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 6, 1926

A military revolt in Goa

Goa, August 5: A small military revolution broke out here on Sunday but it was short-lived. Three garrison Commanding Officers waited on the Acting Governor, Commander Moraes on Sunday the 1st August and demanded the suspension of the New Officers Pay Act. Commander Moraes referred the matter to the Lisbon Government simultaneously requesting his dismissal from the Governor’s charge, if the suspension was granted. Before Lisbon had answered, the Officers intimidated Commander Moraes on Monday that he must withdraw from the Government. He refused, whereupon they took him to Cabo Palace and detained him there. Col. Sequeira assumed the Governorship. The Lisbon Government did not recognise the military Government and ordered that the three officers be dismissed from their charges and their immediate embarkation to Lisbon. Commander Moraes resumed his duty last evening and dismissed the three officers. Then he transferred his powers for reasons of health to the Attorney General. The new Governor-General is expected within a fortnight.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Public grievances received by Centre in last six months

15 lakh. Over 15 lakh public grievances have been received between January and July 15 this year, the Centre said. The government has undertaken initiatives to strengthen the Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System to improve efficiency, quality and accountability. PTI

Occupancy rates across India’s prison system in 2024

112.7 in per cent. India’s prisons operated at 112.7% occupancy in 2024, with 609 jails housing more inmates than their sanctioned capacity and Delhi recording the highest occupancy rate of 194.6%, according to data tabled in the Rajya Sabha on Wednesday. PTI

Number of people executed in Iran since March 19, 2026

56 UN rights chief Volker Turk said on Wednesday he was “alarmed” by the surge in executions in Iran since March, with the death penalty being used by Tehran to “instil fear”. “Since March 19, 2026, at least 56 people have been executed on national security-related charges,” he said. AFP

Number of major online gambling sites banned by Sri Lanka

24 Sri Lanka has blocked access to some of the world’s largest online betting sites as part of a crackdown on unauthorised gambling, the Digital Economy Ministry said. Online gambling is legal in Sri Lanka, but operators must register with the authorities and pay licence fees. AFP

Persons killed in monsoon floods, landslides in India

100 Floods and landslides triggered by monsoon rains have killed more than 100 people across India since July, official data showed on Wednesday, with thousands forced to flee their inundated homes. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The road ahead for the Asiatic lion

Six decades of conservation have increased the Asiatic lion population from about 100-150 to over 1,000, with nearly half now living outside the protected area; however, the species remains confined to single forested landscape, while habitat fragmentation, disease threats continue to pose major conservation challenges

FULL CONTEXT

Meena Venkataraman

The only free-ranging population of the Asiatic lion today survives in and around the Gir National Park and Sanctuary. The semi-arid landscape of Gir extends into expansive agricultural fields and traditional grasslands, forming a checkered landscape matrix. Dispersing lions use these habitats as passages, stepping stones, and refuges as they navigate riverbeds and mountainous terrain, eventually establishing territories far from their source population.

Lions today occupy habitats as ecologically distinct as the rugged hills of Girnar, the forests of Mitiyala, the landscapes around Savarkundla-Liliya, and the sandy coastal tracts stretching across Saurashtra to the Bhavnagar coast. What is perhaps most remarkable is that, at their destinations, these lions are accommodated by the local people.

As is evident, the challenge of lion conservation in Gujarat rests not only on protecting Gir, but also on safeguarding the network of habitats and corridors through which lions disperse and establish new territories. Around 50 lions inhabit the coastal habitats of Jafraabad Taluka, linked to the larger lion population through Babarkot. Significantly, the Gujarat Forest Department’s 2025 lion population estimation identifies this coastal sector as Satellite IV, one of nine recognised satellite lion populations in the State, while the Gir Management Plan explicitly designates the Babarkot area as a lion movement corridor. Together, these official documents recognise the area as both an important satellite habitat and a crucial landscape linkage for dispersing lions.

A crucial corridor under pressure
It is against this backdrop that a recent proposal to divert approximately 75 hectares of reserved forest for limestone



An Asiatic Lioness with four cubs at Gir Sanctuary on May 12, 2025. VIJAY SONEJI

mining has generated concern. The apprehension is that such a move would run counter to the long-standing legal and management framework established to protect lion habitats and movement corridors. If mining were permitted, habitat disruption could functionally disconnect this coastal subpopulation from the larger forest-linked source population and displace lions from portions of their habitat.

The proposed project would reportedly require the felling of nearly 5,000 mature trees and affect a landscape that local communities themselves do not wish to see mined. Human-lion conflict could also intensify. The larger question is whether the prime habitat of a nationally treasured species, a landscape showcasing one of India’s greatest conservation recoveries, should be sacrificed for private profit.

Over the six decades since the declaration of the Gir Sanctuary, the lion population has grown from about 100-150 individuals to a healthy population of over 1,000 today. More admirable, however, is the fact that nearly half of them now reside outside the designated protected area. Lions have, over the years, shown remarkable recovery, expansion and resilience, sustained by a resourceful habitat and a rich prey base.

The unfinished task

This success has been built through a transition from protected-area management to landscape-level conservation, supported by political will, capable administration, sustained funding and the goodwill of local communities. These have been the sturdy pillars of lion conservation.

However, the entire lion population remains confined to a single forested landscape. More puzzling has been the continued resistance to acknowledging the need for a second home for the lions. After years of downplaying the risk of disease in a geographically concentrated population, we received a jolt in 2018 when more than 20 lions succumbed to an outbreak of Canine Distemper Virus (CDV). The forest department responded with a series of immediate measures, but have we effectively applied the lessons learned from previous outbreaks?

Mortality is but a part of a natural demographic cycle. If we are to achieve long-term coexistence in shared spaces, we may even need to accommodate a degree of anthropogenic mortality. Yet the reports of lion deaths associated with babesiosis in May 2026, together with suggestions of possible CDV involvement, are worrying.

If disease exposes the vulnerability of

the population, land-use decisions expose the vulnerability of the landscape that sustains it. These controversies raise a broader question: have the once-strong pillars of the State’s conservation legacy begun to weaken? Are cracks emerging in the framework that has sustained lion conservation for decades? Historically, there was little room for negotiation where lions and their habitat were concerned. Indeed, Gir remains an important case study of how protected areas were progressively expanded around the original sanctuary. Hopefully, there will be no shift in the vision underpinning the law, its application, or administrative decision-making.

Next chapter of recovery

Given the species’ continuing conservation challenges, any ill-advised decision could yet turn the clock back to a far more precarious situation. The International Union for Conservation of Nature Red List tells an encouraging story: the Asiatic lion has moved from Critically Endangered to Endangered. Among the northern lion subpopulations, it is the only stable population exceeding 250 individuals and is therefore of immense global conservation significance. At the same time, the newer Green Status assessments remind us that recovery and restoration are not the same thing.

A species can recover substantially and still remain far from fully restored across its ecological and historical range. Under the Green Status framework, the lion remains largely depleted. While the lion has recovered from the brink, it remains far from fully restored across the landscape it once occupied.

The story of the Asiatic lion is one of sustained recovery achieved through six decades of unwavering conservation effort, and of the responsibility that comes with safeguarding those gains. Our goal is not merely to celebrate this legacy, but to sustain it.

(Meena Venkataraman, PhD, is a wildlife biologist with over two decades of experience in mammalian ecology, with a particular focus on the Asiatic lion)

THE GIST

▼ Landscape-level conservation, backed by political will, capable administration, sustained funding and local community support, has been the foundation of the Asiatic lion’s recovery.

▼ Protecting habitats and movement corridors, addressing disease risks and securing a second home for the species are critical to sustaining India’s lion conservation legacy.

Why is the Indian Statistical Institute Bill controversial?

What changes does the Bill propose to the governance of the ISI?

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

The story so far:

The government has tabled a new Bill in Parliament, called the Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026, which will replace its approximately 67-year-old predecessor enacted in 1959. While seemingly innocuous, several provisions of the Bill have become contentious, with many faculty members of the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) and MPs protesting against it.

What is the ISI?

In the 1920s, India’s greatest statistician P.C. Mahalanobis set up the Statistical Laboratory in the Presidency College in Kolkata. On December 17, 1931, he founded the Indian Statistical Institute as a “learned society” housed in the Statistical Laboratory. The Institute was registered on April 28, 1932, as a non-profit distributing learned society

under the Societies Registration Act of 1860 and is now registered under the West Bengal Societies Registration Act of 1961, amended in 1964. The ISI quickly became India’s premier statistical organisation. It was declared an Institution of National Importance through the Indian Statistical Institute Act, 1959.

What does the Bill seek to change?

At the most basic level, the new Bill seeks to bring ISI’s governance structure on par with that of other Institutions of National Importance, such as the Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs) and the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs).

According to the government, in the IITs and IIMs, compact empowered bodies such as the Board of Governors and executives such as Directors take decisions impacting both the day-to-day functioning and long-term policies of the organisations. However, ISI continues to follow the governance model of a society,

in which significant control is exercised by a large General Body of members of the society. A key outcome of this structure is that any amendment to the regulations can only be carried out with the approval of the General Body.

The government’s contention is that since the regulations are prescriptive, even small reforms require the approval of the General Body.

Therefore, the new Bill is aimed at incorporating ISI into a statutory body corporate, strengthening its legal status and providing a “more robust and contemporary governance framework”.

What will the governance model be?

The new Bill provides for the creation of a compact Board of Governors that will serve as the principal policy-making executive body of the ISI and will be accountable to the government. It also provides for the creation of an Academic Council as the principal academic body. The Board of Governors will consist of

11 members. The Board will be headed by a Chairperson, who is supposed to be an eminent person “in the field of academia, industry, education, public policy, Statistical Sciences and allied sciences, or other fields” and will be nominated by the Visitor (the President of India) on the recommendation of the Centre.

The government will also nominate a government official not below the level of Joint Secretary to the Government of India. The government’s representation will further include another joint secretary or additional secretary.

The Board will include four eminent persons in the field of statistical sciences and allied fields, to be nominated by the Chairperson, and four representatives of the Institute who will include two members of the Academic Council to be nominated by the Board.

The Registrar of ISI will serve as the Secretary of the Board.

What is the controversy around the governance structure?

Ever since the draft Bill was made public last year, professors and officials of ISI have been protesting it. One main contention is that the new governance structure would wrest control of ISI from the people working there and place it in the hands of the Union government. The new structure does give the government direct or indirect control of eight out of the 11 members of the Board of Governors.

Were stakeholders consulted?

The critics say that the Bill has been prepared without consultations with the ISI Society, faculty members, students, or other stakeholders.

The government has argued that as per the review framework in the existing ISI Act, four Review Committees (RCs) have examined the functioning and progress of ISI. The second, third and fourth RCs suggested the reduction in size of the ISI Council, the government said. Despite this, the size of the Council of ISI increased over this period and currently numbers 33 members.

The fourth RC also pointed to certain structural and legacy issues.

Following this, the government said a brainstorming session had been organised by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation on July 2, 2025, in collaboration with the ISI at the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Research in Bengaluru under the Chairpersonship of Dr. K. Radhakrishnan, the current Chairman of the ISI Governing Council. The aim was to “deliberate on pathways that can transform ISI into a world-class centre of learning and research, as it completes 100 years in 2031”.

The government said, as per the pre-legislative consultation policy, comments and suggestions from the public on the draft Bill were invited and the timelines were extended in line with the requests of various stakeholders.

BIBLIOGRAPHY



Keigo Higashino. AFP

Keigo Higashino: chronicler of human nature, crime and conscience

The writer elevated crime fiction beyond the conventional whodunit, using intricate mysteries to explore human nature, moral ambiguity, family dynamics and Japanese society; Higashino’s detective novels and masterful storytelling earned him a lasting global readership

Ramya Kannan

Last month, when Keigo Higashino died of colorectal cancer at the age of 68, reports of his passing seemed like a scene from one of his own novels – a private family funeral and a public mourning, with condolences pouring in on social media. For a fan of Higashino’s writings, the scene, so well described in so many of his novels, played itself out mentally as a sombre Japanese memorial service; you could even smell the incense sticks.

However, for his fans, one sentence rankled. In many reports, he was described as a “Japanese mystery novelist”. But Higashino was not merely a mystery writer; he was among Japan’s best writers. He was as much a chronicler of human nature and the country’s social norms and nuances as he was a writer of intricate, nippy police procedurals – a master storyteller who might have remained confined to his home country had translations not made him available to the world.

The art of the slow reveal
Higashino’s best-known work is *The Devotion of Suspect X*, but a fan would most probably recommend *Newcomer* to a novice.

Going by online bibliographies, Higashino had published “78 novels, 24 short story collections, four essay collections, one children’s book, one manga, and one original audiobook” by

2026. The finest among them were arguably the detective Galileo and detective Kaga mysteries.

The idea that Higashino’s novels are character-driven is beautifully exemplified in *Newcomer*. The book also shows how skillfully he flips the bare-bones mystery format on its head, turning the process of unraveling what led to the crime into a fine work of art.

In *Newcomer*, the gentle, restrained, but astute Inspector Kaga has just been transferred to a new precinct in Nihonbashi. A woman has been strangled to death, and unlike the traditional mystery plot that narrows down the list of suspects, this one spirals outwards. With every chapter, someone new emerges as a suspect – a different shopkeeper each time. It seems probable that anyone could have been the murderer. That is where detective Kaga’s skills come into play: he gently disentangles each thread in this complicated plot until his usual penchant for studying the histories of the characters involved pays off. Secrets from the victim’s past and her activities in the last few days preceding her death lead the reader, hand-held by Kaga, to the murderer.

Science and logic
If *Newcomer* is an uncommon favourite, *The Devotion is Suspect X* is a popular one. This one is led by the enigmatic detective Galileo, a nickname given to him by the police. He is actually Manabu Yukawa, a physicist and friend of detective Kusanagi of the Tokyo police force, who turns to

him for assistance. The physicist then pits his science against a mathematician who has helped the perpetrators conceal the evidence for the murder. Even after it becomes clear to Yukawa who might have been responsible for the murder, he still needs to provide proof that it was an accidental killing that was later covered up. How he does it is a simply riveting read. No wonder the book was adapted into several television series and films, while also inspiring other tales.

Higashino’s hallmark is to subvert the regular whodunit structure, which means the reader often learns of the crime early. So, where does the tension in the text come from? It comes from the slow unraveling of motive and cover-up, and the exploration of guilt, loyalty, and, very often, the psychological cost of deception and how it weighs an individual down. Only an author who is a student of the human condition can describe that kind of insight in such great detail – it takes more effort to connect a crime with social relationships, linking up neighbours and co-workers, studying family dynamics, and unearthing old resentments.

In *A Death in Tokyo*, *Malice*, and *The Final Curtain*, Higashino drags us through the alleyways of the past, sometimes going back years or even generations to find motive in an old injury, an insult, or patterns that make sense in the present, to wind up his investigation.

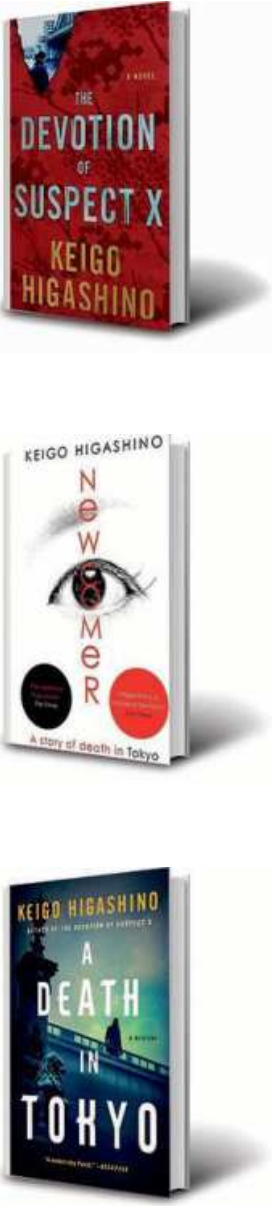
Beyond the whodunit
If a standalone novel is your poison, then pick up a copy of *Journey Under the*

Midnight Sun. It is not a typical procedural, but it is an epic exploration of the toll that an unsolved crime can take on the lives of the people involved. The book, which covers over two decades, tracks the lives of two children who grow into adulthood and explores the dark shadow of a secret hanging over them. Even though it is not a mind-bender like his other books, *Journey...* is a master class in writing about the human mind and its infinite potential to deceive, manipulate, and confound, and even stoop to murder. The moral ambiguity that accompanies crime, an essential human predicament, gets maximum play in Higashino’s work.

Since Higashino is not just a mystery writer, we get a sense of Japan through his works. Through his novels, he allows us to explore the prefectures, food, shops, shrines and customs of his motherland, while capturing how a younger generation is negotiating change in an ageing society steeped in rituals and tradition.

It is safe to say that, apart from all the reels that flood social media, Higashino too has a role to play in increasing interest around the world in Japan as a tourist destination.

As his fans across the world mourn his demise, Higashino still has one last gift. His final, posthumous novel, *Eternal Memory*, was released on August 5. It is the 11th instalment in the detective Galileo series. One more tango with Yukawa’s powerful intellect, and who is to complain, even if it is the last we get?



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“What is the meaning of “sting operation”? (B. Premananda Bhat, Manipal)
A sting operation is a well-planned scheme used by law enforcement agencies to entrap a criminal. It usually involves a lot of undercover work. Often the term is reduced to “sting”. Here are a few examples.

It was a well-planned sting operation. The sting, as expected, went off without a hitch.

The word “sting” has another meaning as well. It is often used in informal contexts to mean “to cheat or overcharge someone”.

(Remember the Robert Redford and Paul Newman movie called “*The Sting*”?) Here are a few examples.

The fruit vendor tried to sting me. The supermarket next to my house makes it a point to sting its customers.

What is the difference between “while” and “whilst”? (S. Anand, New Delhi)
As far as meaning is concerned, there is no difference between the two words; they can be used interchangeably. “Whilst” is considered by some people to be rather old-fashioned. It is mainly used in British English; Americans seldom use it. I understand that even within Britain, “whilst” is more common in the north than in the south. As far as the pronunciation is concerned, the final ‘st’ of ‘whilst’ is pronounced. Here are some examples.

The Police entered the former Chief Minister’s house while/whilst he was sleeping.

Shakunthala called up while/whilst I was having dinner.

Who is a “psephologist”? (Murali Krishnan, Ernakulam)
First, let’s deal with the pronunciation. The first ‘p’ is silent. The ‘se’ in the first syllable sounds like the ‘se’ in ‘set’, ‘sent’, and ‘sell’. The ‘ph’ is pronounced like the ‘f’ in ‘fit’, ‘feet’, and ‘food’. The vowel ‘o’ is like the ‘o’ in ‘got’, ‘not’, and ‘lot’. The ‘o’ in the third syllable sounds like the ‘a’ in ‘China’ and the following ‘g’ is like the ‘j’ in ‘jam’. You can probably guess how the final ‘ist’ is pronounced. It is the second syllable which has the main stress. Psephology is the scientific study of the way in which people vote in elections.

A ‘psephologist’ therefore is someone who studies how people vote – he comes up with the statistics, the trends, etc. These are the people you see on TV during elections telling us about the ‘swing factor’, etc.

Several psephologists were interviewed a day before the elections.

My cousin Mohan wants to be a psephologist when he grows up.

What is the meaning and origin of the expression “to hit the sack”? (A. J. Venkatasubramayam, Bangalore)
This is an informal expression meaning to ‘go to bed’.

Ranjani hit the sack early last night.

The expression became popular during World War II when American soldiers began referring to the sleeping bag/blanket that they were carrying as “sack”. Later, the word “sack” began to be used for anything that one could sleep on – a bed, a table, a bench, etc. The earlier expression that was commonly used was “to hit the hay”.

Published in The Hindu on July 10, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on the tragic atomic bomb attacks on Hiroshima and Nagasaki that took place on August 6 and 9, 81 years ago

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1**
What were the nicknames of the bombs dropped on the two Japanese cities?
- QUESTION 2**
What were the core nuclear materials used in the two bombs?
- QUESTION 3**
Apart from the two unfortunate cities that bore the brunt of the dastardly attack, which other three cities were in the initial list?
- QUESTION 4**
Name the two intended

- aim points in both the cities that were not hit because of weather conditions.
- QUESTION 5**
Which flower became the official flower of Hiroshima because it was the first plant to bloom on the scorched earth following the atomic bombing?
- QUESTION 6**
Which legendary scientist remarked, “Had I known that the Germans would not succeed in developing an atomic bomb, I would have done nothing for the bomb?”



Visual Question:
This is Tsutomu Yamaguchi, a ‘hibakusha’. What is his unique claim to fame as regards the survivors? AP

- Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:**
1. In which year was she awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature? **Ans: 1993**
 2. In 1988, Morrison won the Pulitzer Prize for which of her works? **Ans: Beloved**
 3. Morrison became the first Black female editor for fiction at which publishing house in New York? **Ans: Random House**
 4. In her capacity as an editor, she published two groundbreaking works. One was of a boxing champion, titled ‘The Greatest: My Own Story’, and the other of a little-known novelist and poet who in 1968 had been shot to death by a transit officer in the New York City Subway. Name both the figures. **Ans: Muhammad Ali, Henry Dumas**
 5. Which writer, upon Morrison’s death, said, “Morrison rejected the very concept of the narrow door and claimed for herself the wide world. All readers and writers are indebted to her for the space she created”? **Ans: Zadie Smith**
- Visual:** Identify this boy on whom Toni Morrison wrote her first play. The boy was abducted and lynched in Mississippi in 1955. **Ans: Emmett Till**
- Early Birds:** Tamal Biswas | Sunil Madhavan | Siddhartha Viswanathan | Sudhir Thapa | Piyali Tuli

Word of the day

Axiomatic:
evident without proof or argument

Synonyms: obvious, unmistakable, apparent

Usage: *It is axiomatic that clean water is essential for life.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/axiomatic

International Phonetic Alphabet: /æksɪəməˈtɪk/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

Rijiju meets Rahul in bid to end House logjam

Both Houses witnessed repeated disruptions before being adjourned for the day.

Sources said Mr. Shah was expected to reply to the debate when the FCRA Bill comes up for discussion and passage. “The LoP has made it very clear that they cannot bring the FCRA Bill in this form,” Mr. Venugopal told reporters after the meeting.

“Now you see, the mood of Narendra Modi will change within a minute. If the Indian Opposition says something, he will not listen, but this kind of diktat is coming from a foreign country, they will now...,” he added, when asked about U.S. Congressman Riley M. Moore’s social media post criticising the FCRA Bill.

RBI panel keeps repo rate steady at 5.25%

Taking various factors into consideration, real GDP growth for 2026-27 is projected at 6.7% which is 10 bps higher than the earlier projection, with Q1 at 7.0%; Q2 at 6.4%; Q3 at 6.5%; and Q4 at 6.8%. Real GDP growth for Q1:2027-28 is projected at 7.3%. The risks are evenly balanced.

The Governor said “even though headline inflation is projected to increase, it is primarily on account of supply side pressures caused by food and fuel; it is not getting broad-based; core inflation remains moderate and is expected to decline after peaking in Q3.” “Growth, albeit resilient, is expected to be lower in 2026-27,” he stated.

Meta apologises for ‘errors in operation’

Mr. Kaplan had been summoned, among other things, to explain why Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s first video message to the youth posted on July 23 was temporarily removed from Facebook. The company had attributed it to an error. The government had insisted on full accounting of the error and a personal apology from Mr. Zuckerberg. The informal readout of the meeting did not include a specific reference to that post’s takedown.

“I apologised to the Minister on behalf of Meta for the error restricting PM Modi’s post,” Mr. Kaplan later said in a statement.

The meetings follow heightened discussions around Instagram’s role in amplifying the protests at Jantar Mantar last month, as well as the brief takedown of Mr. Modi’s post on Facebook. Officials asserted that Meta was “not covered under intermediary definition” – a significant statement – since this would make the company liable in court for every single post by users.

Earlier in the day, according to a letter from the Lok Sabha Secretariat, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology, headed by the Bharatiya Janata Party’s Nishikant Dubey, demanded that Google India’s safe harbour be lifted, thereby leaving the firm liable to individual users’ posts as a publisher. The letter, seen by *The Hindu*, cited cyber-crime complaints in Hyderabad where complainants lost over ₹48 lakh to cyberfrauds from apps downloaded from Google Play, where Google’s India country manager was named as a co-accused.

Having majority no reason for lawmakers to defy party, says SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



Justice Joymalya Bagchi

The Supreme Court made it clear on Wednesday that a group of MLAs or MPs cannot override the official directives of the parent political party merely for the reason that they hold a majority among the elected members.

Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said the maturity of a democracy was measured by the constancy of political parties and their members to their ideology. The court was hearing a dispute between the Shiv Sena factions led by Uddhav Thackeray and current Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde over which was the real party and the rightful bearer of the party symbol.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Mr. Thackeray, said “mergers” orchestrated by a faction of MLAs or MPs were not dictated by democratic or ideological powers, but a

naked pursuit of power. “You are carrying this she-nanigan to an absurd level where the entire electoral process becomes a farce because the electoral verdict can be changed through manipulation and defection. The government that comes into existence is not the government that the people voted for. This has huge repercussions,” Mr. Sibal said.

The court, meanwhile, indicated the striking of a balance between the electorate’s decision to vote a party to power and the individual representatives’ liberty to express genuine disagreement with the party’s decisions.

Fear, personal safety cannot decide my duty to the people: Sheikh Hasina

The former Prime Minister of Bangladesh signals return to her country in December despite risk of arrest; demands that ban on Awami League be lifted; she terms India a country that has ‘always been a friend, especially in 1971 and 1975

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, who was deposed in August 2024 following protests, on Wednesday virtually addressed a press conference here, and said “fear” and “concerns of personal safety” will not prevent her from returning home.

In an audio-only broadcast, she said the members of her party, Awami League, have been persecuted and killed, and called for lifting the ban on the party. She termed India a country that has “always been a friend” and supported Bangladesh when it faced difficulties in 1971 and 1975.

“I know, I may be detained. I may be sent to prison, and they may implicate me in fabricated cases. But fear cannot decide my duty to the people, my life or beyond. My life has been beyond the considerations of personal safety for long,”



Sheikh Hasina addresses a virtual press conference by audio in New Delhi on Wednesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

said Ms. Hasina indicating that she may return in December 2026. “You will get to know when I decide to go,” said Ms. Hasina when asked about the date of her return.

Awami League activists said Ms. Hasina will not use a third country to reach Dhaka, and she will take permission from the Indian authorities in December before starting her journey.

Ms. Hasina recounted that she along with her mother were imprisoned in 1971 during the Libera-

tion War and that she lost most of her family members in 1975.

‘People deserve peace’

“Even the August 21, 2004, grenade attack could not stop me. Therefore, I am not worried about my own future. I am worried about the future of Bangladesh. I want to return because people deserve security, development, prosperity and peace,” said Ms. Hasina. She described the protesters of 2024 as “organised” groups that worked accord-

Bangladesh govt. ‘outraged’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bangladesh government said it was “outraged” by Sheikh Hasina’s press conference. “Dhaka deeply regrets that in spite of concerns conveyed *a priori* to the Government of India about the likely

ramifications of this event on the reset of our bilateral relations, this public event was permitted to be held,” the country’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs said.

Bangladesh said that its “repeated requests” to extradite Ms. Hasina to Bangladesh “have not yet elicited a response”.

ing to a “meticulous” plan.

The media event at the Foreign Correspondents Club was the first occasion when Ms. Hasina answered questions from the international media since arriving here on August 5, 2024.

“Fear has entered homes, workplaces and campuses. This is not the Bangladesh that we built,” said Ms. Hasina, accusing the interim government under Mohammed Yunus of scrapping that commission.

On Tuesday, authorities in Bangladesh had urged news outlets to avoid tele-casting the speech and the interaction that was beamed live on social media.

down in law-and-order situation in the country.

Ms. Hasina referred to an investigation committee that she had ordered to probe the uprising of July-August 2024 and accused the interim government under Mohammed Yunus of scrapping that commission.

On Tuesday, authorities in Bangladesh had urged news outlets to avoid tele-casting the speech and the interaction that was beamed live on social media.

2019 marked a new chapter for J&K and Ladakh, says Modi

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday said the reading down of Articles 370 and 35(A) seven years ago marked a decisive new chapter in the journey of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, asserting that the regions have witnessed a wide-ranging transformation since the constitutional provisions were revoked on August 5, 2019.

In a post on X, the Prime Minister said infrastructure has expanded while opportunities in education, healthcare, entrepreneurship and sports have grown significantly in the two Union Territories.

He added that women and marginalised communities, who had been denied their basic constitutional rights for decades,

have been empowered through the full application of the Constitution.

Mr. Modi said this year’s anniversary assumed added significance as India is commemorating the 125th birth anniversary of Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee. He said the vision championed by Mookerjee found historic fulfilment on August 5, 2019. He said the government would continue to work for the progress of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh while ensuring that every citizen gets the opportunity to dream big and contribute to the vision of a Viksit Bharat.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh also marked the occasion, saying the reading down of Articles 370 and 35(A) ushered in a new era of peace, progress and equal opportunity for J&K and Ladakh.

Parties stage protests across J&K on anniversary of Article 370 dilution

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Amid heightened security, the ruling National Conference (NC) and the Opposition Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) held street protests across Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday to mark the seventh anniversary of the dilution of Article 370, which had granted special status to the erst-while State.

Recalling August 5, 2019, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said, “Seven years, we haven’t forgotten, and we haven’t reconciled, far less accepted our current circumstances. My party and I remain committed to reversing all that was done to J&K that took away our rights and threatens our identity...”

Several NC leaders and legislators held protests in their respective constituencies across the Union



Police try to stop National Conference leaders and supporters during a protest in Srinagar on Wednesday. IMRAN NISSAR

Territory. Senior Minister Sakina Itoo led a protest at the party headquarters in Srinagar, where NC leaders carried placards demanding the restoration of J&K’s special status. “August 5 will always be observed by us as a Black Day,” said NC legislator Ahsan Pardesi.

NC Minister Javed Rana said the emotions associated with August 5 remain as profound today as they

were then. “Time may have moved forward, but our resolve has only grown stronger... Our commitment has never been about confrontation; it has always been about restoring dignity, democratic rights, constitutional guarantees and the trust of our people through lawful and peaceful means,” said Mr. Rana.

Following a call by the Opposition PDP, party

Misri calls for provincial elections in Sri Lanka

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri on Wednesday urged the Sri Lankan leadership to hold the long-delayed elections to the Provincial Councils “at the earliest” and to “fully implement” constitutional provisions to meet the aspirations of the Tamil people, according to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

Issued following Mr. Misri’s day-long visit to Colombo, the Ministry’s statement further highlighted bilateral discussions on Indian assistance to Sri Lanka’s recovery from Cyclone Ditrwah, collaborations in the energy sector, and possible upgrade of the trade agreement.

A media statement from President Anura Kumara Dissanayake’s office said the discussions focused on “further strengthening cooperation”. However, it made no mention of any discussion of the provincial elections, revealing an apparent difference in the two sides’ priorities in messaging.

Cabinet and Home Secretaries get extension

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan and Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan’s tenures have been extended for another year, according to a government order issued on Wednesday.

Mr. Mohan was appointed Home Secretary in 2024 and assumed office on August 23, 2024.

“The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) has approved extension in the service of Govind Mohan as Home Secretary, Ministry of Home Affairs for a period of one year, that is up to 22.8.2027,” the order said.

The ACC, led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the extension for Mr. Somanathan as Cabinet Secretary for a further period of one year beyond August 30, 2026, an order issued by the Personnel Ministry said.

‘Police modernisation scheme awaits Finance Ministry’s nod’

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Union government informed the Supreme Court on Wednesday that a proposal seeking in-principle approval for an umbrella scheme for the modernisation of police forces across the country had been sent to the Department of Expenditure under the Union Ministry of Finance.

Additional Solicitor-General Rajkumar Bhaskar Thakare, appearing for the Centre, told a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta that the proposal was forwarded on July 8, 2026 and was currently under consideration.

The submission was made in a *suo motu* proceeding initiated in 2025 after the court took note of a media report highlighting non-functional CCTV cameras at police stations in Udaipur, Rajasthan. The court had subsequently sought compliance reports from the Centre, States,

The Centre made the submission before the SC in a hearing on non-functional CCTV cameras at police stations

and Union Territories while reviewing the implementation of its 2021 judgment in *Paramvir Singh Saini vs Baljit Singh*, which mandated the installation of CCTV cameras at key locations within police stations.

Earlier, the Bench had urged the Union government to consider requests from States for the release of funds to install CCTV cameras and establish a centralised monitoring dashboard covering police stations.

On Wednesday, Justice Mehta asked whether the proposed umbrella scheme would be confined to infrastructure or would also extend to the augmentation of human resources. Mr. Thakare informed

the Bench that the scheme was intended to cover the modernisation of the police force as a whole.

Describing the development as “significant progress”, the Bench directed the Centre to place details of the proposal on record through an affidavit within two weeks, and posted the matter for further hearing on September 1.

The Bench was also informed that the Assistance to States and Union Territories for Modernisation of Police scheme, under which the Ministry of Home Affairs provides financial assistance for CCTV infrastructure at police stations, had been extended until March 31, 2027.

Senior advocate Siddhartha Dave, assisting the court as *amicus curiae*, expressed concern that some States were seeking funds for additional police vehicles instead of prioritising modern equipment and scientific methods of investigation.

Woman ‘blamed for rape, humiliated’ by panchayat in Bihar

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

A 30-year-old woman in Begusarai district of Bihar has alleged that after being raped by her neighbour, she was subjected to public humiliation instead of receiving justice.

According to her complaint, villagers caught the accused while he was allegedly trying to flee by breaking a window. They then convened a village panchayat and allegedly humiliated her in front of those present.

A purported video showing the woman being humiliated went viral on social media, triggering widespread outrage.

As per the FIR, lodged on Saturday, the mother of two children was allegedly raped twice on June 2 and 4, when her husband, who works as a labourer in another State, was away from the village. The woman lodged the complaint

after her husband returned to the village on June 25.

The complaint states that during the panchayat meeting on July 5, 2026, she was asked to hold her ears and kneel, and was allegedly forced to lick her own spit after the village panchayat declared that it was all her fault.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Deputy Superintendent of Police (Headquarters), Begusarai, Nikhil Kumar, said, “Police have lodged the FIR based on the complaint of the woman. The incident took place two months back, in which she has alleged that she was threatened by the accused and raped...”

He further said, “Both the accused and the woman were subjected to humiliation.”

When contacted, Sub-Divisional Police Officer, Ballia, Subodh Kumar, said one person, who is the son of a ward councillor, had been arrested in the case.

Protests stall Parliament for 13th consecutive day

Houses witness repeated disruptions over donation theft and police action against protesters; Lok Sabha passes Bankers' Books Evidence Bill without debate; Rijiju slams MPs for staging skits

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Disruptions continued in both Houses of Parliament for the 13th consecutive day on Wednesday, with the Opposition persisting in its protests over the alleged Ram Temple donation scam and its demand for a statement from Union Home Minister Amit Shah on last month's police action against protesters.

The government has not extended any assurance on either issue.

In the Lok Sabha, Opposition MPs trooped into the Well of the House as soon as it convened in the morning and began shouting slogans and displaying placards. Speaker Om Birla asked MPs to allow the House to function and take up Question Hour. However, as they remained unrelenting, he adjourned the House till 2 p.m.



Stormy session: Rajya Sabha proceedings under way during the Monsoon Session of Parliament in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANI

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju criticised Opposition MPs for staging skits in the Parliament House complex to protest the alleged theft of donations.

He claimed that the Congress, the Communist parties, and the Samajwadi Party had opposed the construction of the temple and were against Lord Ram.

When the Lok Sabha re-

convened at 2 p.m., the Bankers' Books Evidence Bill was taken up, with Opposition members continuing to raise slogans in the Well of the House. The Bill was taken up for consideration and passed by a voice vote without debate.

"We had given time for discussion, but they [the Opposition] disrupted proceedings," Mr. Rijiju said. Referring to Congress leader K.C. Venugopal as a

"good man", he said Mr. Venugopal should make his party members understand the importance of debate.

He added that the government was open to discussions as decided in meetings of the Business Advisory Committee, but the Opposition should not exert pressure.

Adjournments in RS too
Similar scenes were witnessed in the Rajya Sabha, which saw two adjournments during the first half of the day. A few members managed to deliver their speeches during Zero Hour, which allows MPs to raise issues of national importance. Rajya Sabha Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan criticised the Opposition for not adhering to the rules of conduct. His repeated appeals to maintain order were ignored by both sides, and the Upper House was adjourned after 26 minutes till noon.

Learn from seniors, stay clear of 'intrigues in Delhi', PM tells new NDA RS MPs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday cautioned newly elected Rajya Sabha members of the National Democratic Alliance against falling prey to the "intrigues in Delhi", and urged them to learn from all parliamentarians, including those in the Opposition, during their tenure in the Upper House.

Mr. Modi hosted 37 newly elected Rajya Sabha MPs for breakfast. Among the tips shared by the Prime Minister was a caution about the "web of intrigues" in the Lutyens' Zone of Delhi.

"Be mindful of whom you meet and where you meet. Delhi is a dangerous place," he is reported to have told the MPs. The caution was an echo of a similar warning to NDA MPs during the alliance's Parliamentary Party meet after the 2019 Lok Sabha election. In that speech, Mr. Modi had said that first-



Warm welcome: Prime Minister Narendra Modi meeting the new Rajya Sabha MPs in New Delhi on Wednesday. X/@NARENDRAMODI

time MPs might meet many people eager to serve them, and later these very people could lead to their downfall – the allusion was to not getting caught among middlemen. On Wednesday, the Prime Minister reiterated the advice.

Mr. Modi also instructed the MPs to guard against the misuse of their letterhead and to avoid being rude to people on the phone.

PM's personal routine
Responding to questions about his personal routine,

he told the group that he falls asleep within eight seconds of getting into bed and that he sleeps for only three hours.

He added that it is important to live in the moment to get optimum results. "Right now, I am with you, so I am not thinking about anything else. I think about and live in the moment I am in," he reportedly said.

Those who attended the meeting included BJP president Nitin Nabin, Tarun Chugh, Vinod Tawde, Swati Maliwal, Raghav Chadha, and Ashok Mittal.

Over 43 lakh voters deleted from draft rolls in Jharkhand

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Almost 16.5% of Jharkhand voters' names have been removed in the draft electoral rolls published by the State Election Commission on Wednesday after the enumeration phase of the on-going special intensive revision (SIR) of voter lists.

Of the 43.6 lakh names that have been removed, over seven lakh are dead, over 14 lakh untraceable, and over 15 lakh have permanently shifted away from the State, Jharkhand Chief Electoral Officer K. Ravi Kumar told presspersons in Ranchi. Another 1.16 lakh voters refused to sign their enumeration forms and did not return them to the booth-level officers (BLOs).

"As many as 43,61,987 voters have been removed, falling under the 'Absent, Shifted, Dead, or Duplicate' (ASDD) categories," Mr. Kumar said.

Second chance

He pointed out that eligible electors whose names existed in the 2026 electoral roll but who failed to submit the enumeration form can still be added back to the rolls during the claims and objections phase from August 5 to September 4. They are required to sub-

1.8 lakh voters excluded from Meghalaya rolls

SHILLONG

Around 1.8 lakh electors have been excluded from draft electoral roll of Meghalaya published on Wednesday after the special intensive revision identified them as deceased, shifted, untraceable or duplicate, officials said. They clarified that the cases will be examined during the claims and objections phase. PTI

mit Form-6 along with the declaration form.

"The Election Commission (EC) is implementing the SIR of the Electoral Rolls in Jharkhand with a clearly defined objective to ensure inclusion of all the eligible citizens of India in the electoral roll and exclusion of all the ineligible electors from the electoral roll with full transparency at every stage of the process," Mr. Kumar said.

"As on July 29, out of 2,64,63,236 electors, 2,21,01,249 (83.51%) electors have submitted their enumeration forms, reflecting an overwhelming participation in the enumeration phase of the SIR," Mr. Kumar said.

The SIR process began in Jharkhand on June 30.

Rahul using children to build political narrative: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party on Wednesday accused the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi of taking a "selective approach" to students' issues by highlighting protests in Delhi while ignoring the ongoing agitation in Congress-ruled Jharkhand.

Responding to Mr. Gandhi's charge that Union Minister Amit Shah was responsible for the violence against young protesters during the march on July 20, BJP MP and spokesperson Sambit Patra accused him of attempting to "build a political narrative through children".

Mr. Patra clarified that his remarks were not directed at the children who accompanied Mr. Gandhi during his press conference, but solely at the Congress leader.

He accused Mr. Gandhi of indulging in the "wrong practice" of "using innocent children as a means to pursue politics". Stating that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP were with them, Mr. Patra said children need not hesitate to participate in movements or protests whenever necessary.

He also accused Mr. Gandhi of disrupting the functioning of the House.

Rahul steps up attack on Shah; protesters recount police action during march

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Wednesday accused Union Home Minister Amit Shah of being responsible for the alleged police excesses recently directed at students protesting against examination paper leaks.

Mr. Gandhi said Mr. Shah lacked the "decency" and "courage" to explain the incident in Parliament.

Addressing the media here, Mr. Gandhi said he had met students from different States, who had participated in the protests. He was proud of the "thousands of students" who had fought for the Constitution, the education system, and the future of the country, he said.

The students had narrated how they were assaulted, beaten and threatened despite protesting peacefully, Mr. Gandhi said. "Complaining about a flawed education system is not a crime. The system needs to be changed and corrected," he said.

Stepping up his attack on the Union Home Minister, Mr. Gandhi said, "There are two possibilities – either he did not know that violence was



Voicing out: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi with a few protesters at a press conference in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

carried out on children, in which case he is incompetent, or he ordered it, which means he is culpable. Either way, he is responsible."

Later, Mr. Gandhi shared photographs from his interaction with students on Instagram, describing the students as "young, fearless, outspoken and patriotic". "And the Prime Minister and Home Minister? Neither the courage to come to Parliament nor the guts to provide answers," he posted.

Protesters speak up

Among those who addressed the media alongside Mr. Gandhi was model Rhiya Ahir, whose photograph blocking a police van during the student protests in Mumbai went viral. Ms. Ahir said she had prevented the unlawful ar-

rest of students and was now facing sustained online harassment. "This is not trolling, it is a crime," she said.

Other students, including Nutan Topo, Farha Naz, Bharat, and Muskan Sharma, also spoke to the media, giving their personal accounts of alleged police brutalities against them at Jantar Mantar.

Ms. Topo alleged that she was hit by pellet firing during the July 20 demonstration. Ms. Naz claimed that police personnel, after finding out her name, labelled her "anti-national". Mr. Bharat alleged he was beaten during the agitation, and said it was important to protest to safeguard democracy.

Mr. Gandhi hailed the students for speaking publicly despite facing harassment.

HC orders removal of deepfake videos targeting Gadkari

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court directed social media platforms on Wednesday to take down deepfake and AI-generated videos that linked Union Minister Nitin Gadkari to the ethanol blending programme (EBP). The court found the content to be defamatory.

Justice Arif Doctor, presiding over a Single Bench, ordered the removal of all content highlighted by Mr. Gadkari in his lawsuit. The court also issued a directive to remove any similar content in the future if brought to its attention by the Minister.

The order came in response to a suit filed by the Union Minister, who asserted that he had no role in the ethanol blending programme decision-making process. He stated that the policy was managed by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

'False portrayal'

Mr. Gadkari, who has been the Union Minister of Road Transport since 2014, told the court that unknown users had created and circulated videos that falsely portrayed him as responsible for the implementation of the ethanol blending policy. The content also

RS clears Bill to increase number of SC judges

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Rajya Sabha passed the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill even as the Opposition members walked out before voting on the Bill. The Bill, passed in the Lok Sabha on Monday, is a Money Bill and the Upper House returned it to the Lower House after a discussion.

The Bill increases the number of Supreme Court judges from the present strength of 34 to 38, including the Chief Justice of India. The Bill replaces an Ordinance issued by the government in May. Opposition members questioned the "hurry" for bringing the Ordinance. "Why was this not brought as an Act straight to the Parliament?" asked Congress MP and senior lawyer Vivek Tankha, who initiated the debate.

Replying to the debate, Minister of State for Law and Justice Arjun Ram Meghwal said the increase of judges is a step to improve judicial efficiency.



Nitin Gadkari

made allegations that he and his family had derived undue financial benefits from the programme, implying corruption and misuse of office.

The suit referenced at least 24 posts that contained such allegations. Mr. Gadkari clarified that his legal action was not intended to suppress fair debate or criticism of government policies but to address content that was fabricated and malicious. He also noted that the deepfake content exploited his personality and publicity rights without his consent.

During the proceedings, the court expressed concern over the absence of a mechanism to remove abusive content without judicial intervention. It observed that individuals are compelled to approach courts for relief in such matters.

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The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites www.iob.bank.in & www.gem.gov.in For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website www.gem.gov.in

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Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, Anna Salai, Chennai-600002
Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:
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BID NO: GEM/2026/B/7853129 DATED 30.07.2026
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Tender No	Description	Due Date
262713 003026	Supply of Thermal Rolls made out of TNPL Paper	20.08.2026

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website and NIC Portal only. Detailed Terms & Conditions are available in tender document at our websites: www.tnpl.com / www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgep/app
DIPR/2447/TENDER/2026 **TNPL - Maker of bagasse based eco-friendly Paper**

ODISHA JOINT ENTRANCE EXAMINATION-2026 (OJEE-2026)
No: OJEE / 387 **Date : 05.08.2026**
NOTICE FOR NEET UG 2026 QUALIFIED STATE CANDIDATES
Congratulation to all NEET 2026(UG) qualified candidates of the State.
Admission to MBBS/BDS State Quota seats of different Government and Hi-Tech/ Dreams Medical (Private) Colleges of the State will be done for the session 2026-27 on the basis of NEET 2026 (UG) merit list following rules and regulation of the State Govt.
The online registration and counselling process for state merit list preparation **starts from 06.08.2026**, for other detail schedule, Instructions/Guideline please visit OJEE website. Candidates are advised to keep in touch with website www.ojee.nic.in / www.odishajee.com and OJEE Android/loS App for latest information.
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Short e-Tender Call Notice for Procurement of TC-Pomegranate Plantlets for the year-2026-27
NIT No. OSSC/Mktg (Hort)-23/2026
Interested bidders may visit the short e-tender portal i.e. www.tendersodisha.gov.in for downloading the document for Procurement of TC-Pomegranate Plantlets for the year-2026-27.
Last date of receipt of tender in portal - **12.08.2026 up-to 05.00 PM.**
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Managing Director, OSSC Ltd.
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Ph: +91-020-25898390/25899273
NOTICE OF INVITATION OF EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
This department intends to solicit EOI from interested collaborators for submission of project proposal on Photonic Packaging to MeitY. EOI start **date: 05.08.2026** and last date of submission : **23.08.2026**
Note: For detailed information visit <https://cmef.gov.in>
Sd/-
In-charge Administration

INBRIEF



Meghalaya launches mission to protect clouded leopards

Meghalaya has launched a dedicated programme for its State animal—the mainland clouded leopard (*Neofelis nebulosa*). On Tuesday, Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma unveiled Mission Clouded Leopard. “The mission covers habitat protection and restoration, scientific research and long-term monitoring, stronger protection measures, landscape connectivity, capacity building of frontline staff, community participation, and public awareness. It will be guided by the Meghalaya Clouded Leopard Action Plan, now being prepared by the Forest and Environment Department,” the Chief Minister said.

Top court allows reportage on proceedings, curbs use of clips

The Supreme Court has clarified on July 31 that recognised news outlets can continue to report on court proceedings, but without “utilising” audio and video clippings of judicial hearings. This would mean that recognised news outlets cannot post raw or edited audio and video content on social media or digital platforms, ostensibly for commercial purposes. On July 31, a Bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant clarified its July 24 interim order, which barred the unauthorised sharing, posting, monetisation or storage of recordings of judicial proceedings on digital platforms without prior approval.

Petition seeks disclosure of identity of shop owners

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday granted six weeks to several States and Union Territories to respond to a public interest litigation (PIL) petition seeking directions requiring shop owners to display their identity, registration details and number of employees at their establishments to enable consumers to pursue complaints under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta was hearing a petition filed by lawyer and BJP leader Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay seeking such disclosure requirements as a measure to safeguard consumer rights. “We grant six weeks’ time to the respondents who have not filed responses to file the same,” the Bench said.

DGMA warns of rising cyberthreats as ports adopt digital technologies

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

With ports increasingly adopting digital technologies and automation, cyberthreats have emerged as a potential risk to maritime security and the continuity of port operations, the Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) has cautioned in a fresh advisory.

Referring to the International Ship and Port Facility Security Code, the DGMA said the growing dependence of modern ports on interconnected information technology and operational technology systems had created new vulnerabilities that could adversely affect the safety, security and functioning of port facilities.

The advisory said terminal operating systems, cargo handling infrastructure, vessel traffic management systems, access control

Working to address students’ concerns, says Jharkhand CM

Hundreds of students are demanding a CBI inquiry into alleged irregularities in competitive exams, cancellation of the 14th JPSC prelims, and a review of exams conducted through agencies

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

As a student protest over alleged irregularities in competitive examinations entered its 12th day in Ranchi, Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Wednesday assured demonstrators that appropriate action was being taken to address their concerns.

Hundreds of students have gathered at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in the State capital, demanding an inquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) followed by action against those responsible for alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs in the State, including in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) Combined Civil Services Examination, and the Jharkhand General Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination, which is also known as Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level exam.

The protesters have also called for the cancellation of the Preliminary Test of the 14th JPSC Civil Services



A medical worker checks Devendra Nath Mahto's blood pressure at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in Ranchi on Wednesday. PTI

Examination, and a review of exams conducted through agencies, including TSR Data Processing Private Ltd.

“The concerns of my students are extremely serious matter for us. The issue of paper leaks is not confined to Jharkhand; it has become a major national problem affecting the youth across many States. Our government is working on this matter with utmost seriousness. The relevant agencies are conducting investigations day and night and the culprits are being sent to jail as well,” Mr. Soren told presspersons in Ranchi.

“The doors of the government are open to everyone. Any student or candidate who has a demand

sition in the State Assembly, Babulal Marandi, visited the stadium to meet the protesting students. “The BJP stands with the students on this issue, supporting them both on the streets and in the Legislative Assembly. This matter will be raised in the Assembly as well,” Mr. Marandi said.

Sub-Divisional Officer (Ranchi Sadar) Kumar Rajat and Additional District Magistrate (Law and Order) Dhananjay Kumar met the students with the government’s proposals, urging them to send a delegation to the Chief Minister’s residence for talks. The students refused, urging the officials to bring the Chief Minister to the protest venue for talks instead.

The Jharkhand government has issued prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS within a 750-metre radius of the Assembly, an official said. The order will be effective from 8 a.m. on August 6 to 10 p.m. on August 12, prohibiting unlawful assembly of five or more persons, processions, marches, and demonstrations. (With PTI inputs)

Listen to Gen Z, don’t repress them, says SC on NEET-UG protests

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday struck a parental tone, saying reasoning with students, youth, and organisers involved in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET-UG) paper leak protests would be a better option than taking an aggressive stance against them.

“A better way is to counsel them, pacify them... The most powerful resource is reasoning. To listen to them. The government knows how to deal with it,” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said.

The court was hearing a petition filed by a retired Air Force officer, Manish Kumar Solanki, who said the government was on the “backfoot” and “bending over backwards” to accommodate the “organisers” of Cockroach Janta Party-linked (CJP) demonstration, that drew students and youth from across the country and ultimately led to a police crackdown in Delhi on July 20.

Mr. Solanki’s counsel said no action had been taken against the organisers 15 days after the July 20 incident. He said the CJP was not even a registered or-

ganisation. “The government is bending backwards to accommodate them. Violence, meanwhile, is continuing. A youth died in Rajasthan. In [a] society, everybody is important, including the farmers who had agitated and the protesters of Shaheen Bagh... If the government is on the backfoot, society and the institutions of law cannot be seen to be on the backfoot,” advocate Rizwan Ahmed, appearing for the petitioner, submitted.

“Stone-pelters cannot be allowed to go scot-free just because the government is on the back foot. Tomorrow, Generation Alpha, Beta, Gamma may come...,” he argued. The petitioner suggested that the “young boys and girls” should be asked to do seven days of community service. But the CJI advised conciliation, counselling and peace.

“Youngsters are required to be pacified, even if some among them are involved in stone-pelting. They need a lot of advice and counselling. Any aggression will only unnecessarily aggravate the situation and lead to further violations. That needs to be avoided,” the CJI said.

SC seeks action on illegal constructions, warns civic authorities of contempt

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday pulled up civic authorities in State capitals for failing to act against illegal constructions and the unauthorised use of residential premises for non-residential purposes despite its earlier directions. The court also restrained municipal authorities from issuing directions contrary to its orders, warning that any interference could invite contempt proceedings.

“...Irrespective of any order that may be in operation, our directions shall be fully complied with by the authorities concerned... This will apply pan-India. We are indicating that if there is any attempt by any authority or government to interfere with any order of this



court, the court may not show such restraint in issuing notice of contempt against the concerned authority, government or individual,” a Bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R. Mahadevan said.

The Bench directed civic authorities across the country to identify illegal constructions within their respective jurisdictions and take action “without any delay”. It also directed them to ensure that public spaces and roads were cleared of stray cattle and to file compliance affidavits

within three weeks.

The directions were issued in a case arising from Tamil Nadu concerning a construction carried out in violation of land use norms and building bye-laws. In March this year, the court had expanded the scope of the proceedings and issued notices to civic bodies in several State capitals, seeking details of action taken against similar violations.

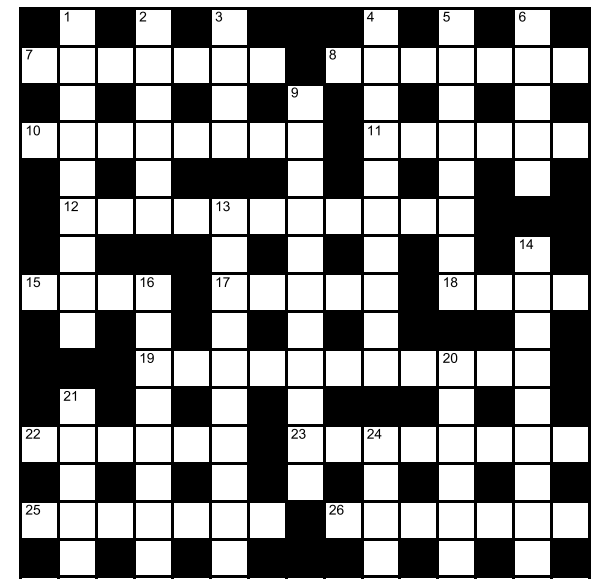
On Wednesday, Additional Solicitor-General K.M. Nataraj told the top court that the Bhopal Municipal Corporation had sealed about 100 premises for violations but later unsealed them after the State paused action and formed a panel to frame a policy on commercial establishments in residential areas. He urged the court to restrain the State from interfering with the civic body’s statutory functions.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14865

(set by Vidwan)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

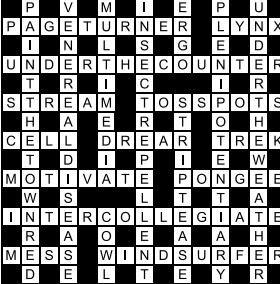
- 7 Love on the rebound! Strove after losing his heart and matured! (7)
8 Fair basis of sharing a part or split (3,4)
10 Sick one, very engrossed in exploit that is unreal (8)
11 500 make love and magic! (6)

- 12 Disapproving sound, it reflects female habit! It transforms into a sweet flavour! (5-6)
15 Years ago, devised by Patanjali (4)
17 Some irritate heedlessly and snigger (2-3)
18 Soil in Buffalo, America (4)
19 He devours or cooks appetiser (4,7)
22 One who holds liquor without a hint of restraint? (6)
23 South ignored marketed name, welcomed learner and earlier partner (3,5)
25 One about to get married in cafe around England (7)
26 Flower within my grasp (7)
Down
1 Advance a prop, possibly for overpopulation (9)
2 Female relative hosting large parade (6)
3 This Himalayan man is still fictional essentially (4)
4 A teen mostly locked in closet with latest issue of Nancy Drew, perhaps (7,3)
5 Provide weapons to old hide-out, rockets and heraldry (8)
6 Small and also large seat (5)
9 Shape of toned heart throbs (11)
13 Teen birder struggling to mix (10)
14 Something that prevents copyright violations with a model English royal brand (9)
16 Fan promotion at this place? Not on vacation! (8)
20 Twisting and turning sound, time for mass (6)
21 Unfortunately tries to appear in examination again (5)
24 No more fear! No resistance! (4)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Right way to respond

Whenever someone scolds a Vaishnava, he must assume that he deserves it. Acharya Nampillai demonstrated this in an incident, said M.A. Venkatakrishnan in a discourse. A person called Kandadai Thozhappan abused Nampillai with the most hurtful words. Later Thozhappan’s wife told him how wrong it was to abuse a great Acharya like Nampillai. Thozhappan decided that the next morning he would visit Nampillai and seek his forgiveness. The next morning, when he opened the door of his house, he found someone sitting on the pyol. Before he could ask the man what he wanted, the visitor fell at Thozhappan’s feet and asked for forgiveness. Only then did Thozhappan notice that the visitor was Nampillai! Nampillai explained: “You are the descendant of a great man. I must have done something wrong. Otherwise, why would you have scolded me? I am here to ask for your forgiveness.” Thozhappan was moved and told Nampillai, “You have proved through your action that you are an Acharya for whole world.”

The 15th pasuram of Thiruppavai shows that if someone accuses us of having a bad trait, we should willingly accept the abuse, even if the accuser is the one who has the bad trait. In this verse, those outside the room in which a girl has been sleeping say, “We know all about your sharp tongue and your harsh words.” The girl inside the room replies, “You are the ones with a sharp tongue. But never mind. Let me be the one who has this quality.” Thus, the girl accepts the insult thrown at her, without retaliating. To show the importance of such tolerance on the part of Vaishnavites, this verse is placed in the middle of Thiruppavai.

INBRIEF



Centre awards LoIs for 11 new flying training schools

The Centre on Tuesday issued Letters of Intent (LoIs) for the establishment of 11 new Flying Training Organisations (FTOs) across seven airports operated by the Airports Authority of India (AAI). With the addition of these 11 FTOs, India's annual pilot training capacity is expected to increase by 750 cadets, providing a significant boost to the domestic training ecosystem, the Ministry of Civil Aviation said in a statement.

Air India appoints Tewolde Gebremariam as its new CEO

Air India has appointed Tewolde Gebremariam as its new CEO. A former Ethiopian Airlines chief, he was most recently selected to lead Pakistan International Airlines. He will succeed Campbell Wilson, the first chief executive appointed after Air India was privatised and handed over to the Tata Group in 2022. Mr. Wilson stepped down from the role in April but continued to serve until his successor was appointed.

Services sector growth hits four-and-a-half-year low

India's services sector growth fell to a four-and-a-half-year low in July as new business orders eased in both domestic and export markets, constrained by fierce competition and fading demand, a monthly survey said on Wednesday. The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Services PMI Business Activity Index fell from 57.4 in June to 53.3 in July, registering the weakest growth rate in close to four-and-a-half years.

RBI to resume licensing of urban cooperative banks

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is set to resume licensing of urban cooperative banks (UCBs) after a pause of more than two decades as part of developing a vibrant co-operative sector in the country. "It has been decided to resume licensing of UCBs on 'on tap' basis," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra announced as one of the additional measures. Draft guidelines would be issued shortly for stakeholder consultation, he added. A discussion paper on licensing of UCBs was published for stakeholder feedback on January 13, 2026 and the decision has been taken based on feedback from stakeholders. As per RBI and NABARD, there are 1,457 urban cooperative banks. The RBI has also decided to review the guidelines on concentration risk management of rural co-operative banks (RCBs). Highlighting the banking sector in general and co-operative banking sector in particular, have undergone significant expansion and changes over 18 years, it said there was a need to review prudential norms on concentration risk management of RCBs. These are governed by the Credit Monitoring Arrangement (CMA) instructions issued in 2008. The Reserve Bank of India proposed to rationalise the regulatory framework on interest rates for all regulated entities (REs) on an in-principle basis. The move is aimed at harmonising guidelines across REs while maintaining proportionality.

SIAM withdraws letter to Centre flagging chloride related concerns with E20

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) late on Tuesday withdrew its earlier letter to the government flagging concerns about vehicular parts experiencing either corrosion or wear and tear due to high chloride presence in E20 fuel, saying the data would require further authentication. In its latest statement, the auto industry body said concerns it had raised earlier had been addressed. A draft of the earlier letter to the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) accessed by The Hindu stated, "SIAM members are observing huge increase in the issues in customer vehicle parts and replacement (like fuel injectors, fuel pump, exhaust gas recirculation valve, exhaust and other parts that are in direct contact with fuel or engine emission gases)." The letter goes on to state 'investigations of field failure vehicle parts reveal the failure is due to corrosion or wear caused by high chloride presence which is traced to the fuel used,' adding deposits in failed parts also showed the presence of chlorides. However, in a social media post past midnight on Monday, SIAM clarified the data it had cited required further authentication through the "collection of elaborate data from various regions across the country followed by a comprehensive consultation with our member OEMs". SIAM did not, however, mention why it had included unauthenticated data in its letter to MoPNG.



Volte-face: The auto industry body said concerns it had raised earlier had been addressed. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Chloride contamination has the potential to corrode and permanently damage engine and other vehicular parts either immediately or over a period of time depending on the contamination level. Reacting to SIAM's previous letter, Tehseen Poonawalla, founder of citizens' advocacy collective Team Bharat, said it contradicted Union Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari's assertions about there being no vehicular damage because of the blended fuel. "A direct side-by-side technical evaluation of both documents exposes alarming contradictions that severely undermine the technical authority of the auto industry's premier apex body, giving the distinct impression of an institutional retreat under administrative duress of Nitin Gadkari ji as he had made tall claims," Mr. Poonawalla said. Mr. Poonawalla also called for accountability from OEMs, emphasising they must now be "transparent with citizens" and urged the Petroleum Ministry to scout for ways to control chloride contamination. SIAM stated in its previous letter it had come

across chloride contamination of as much as 500 milligrams for every kilogram (mg/kg) in the fuel samples collected from vehicular tanks it inspected. It specified fuel chloride contamination was among the reasons it observed while analysing engine oils of failed vehicles. 'Excess moisture' SIAM in the now-withdrawn letter had also observed issues relating to "excess moisture" in the ethanol blended fuel. In its statement withdrawing the letter, however, it emphasised that oil-marketing companies have instituted necessary checks, including water ingress testing about 8-12 times a day in over 87,000 outlets and after each spell of rain near petrol pumps. The clarification came after the automobile manufacturers' body had stated that high moisture content – of more than 1% in fuels – caused separation of the fuel and damaged the vehicle immediately after fuelling. "Even though the moisture level permitted in the E20 fuel is 3000 mg/kg, we have observed values even beyond 10,000 mg/kg level [1%] in many cases," it said.

India said to mull levy on gas users to fund \$42-bn fuel reserve

Reuters
NEW DELHI

India may impose a charge on cooking and natural gas consumers to help fund a planned \$42 billion strategic fuel reserve, according to two sources with direct knowledge of the matter, after disruptions from the Iran war exposed supply chain vulnerabilities. The plan would extend India's strategic reserves beyond crude oil for the first time, with stockpiles designed to cover about two months of crude and liquefied natural gas demand and around six weeks of liquefied petroleum gas or cooking gas consumption, the two sources said. Under the plan, cooking and natural gas storage infrastructure would be financed through levies on users that could raise about \$1.5 billion annually, the two sources said. India's Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas is considering a levy of ₹1.29 (\$0.0136) per kg of LPG, which would raise about \$460 million a year based on current consumption and add about ₹18 rupees to the cost of a standard domestic cooking gas cylinder, the sources said. For natural gas, the Ministry proposed a levy of ₹1.43/standard cubic metre, generating about \$1 billion a year at current consumption levels. The proposed levies would add about 2% to household gas bills. India is the world's third-largest oil importer and consumer. It buys almost 90% of the crude from overseas, which exposed it to the turmoil from the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran.

RBI has enough funds to pay for UPI use

The government has introduced a Bill in Parliament that will allow it to notify the kinds of transactions that can attract such a charge; However, an analysis by The Hindu has found that RBI itself has sufficient funds to pay for the platform's use without having to charge merchants or customers

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday said that "someone will have to pay the cost" of UPI transactions, which are currently free for merchants and customers. The cost is currently being borne by banks and the National Payment Corporation of India. Mr. Malhotra was responding to media queries in the context of recent moves by the government to pave the way for a charge to be levied on such transactions. If implemented, certain merchants would have to pay banks for the use of the UPI platform, which experts say they would pass

on to customers. An analysis by The Hindu has found that the RBI itself has more than enough funds to pay for the UPI platform's use, without involving any additional charge on merchants or customers. This additional cost would amount to between 3-8.5% of what the central bank transferred to the Union government as its annual surplus. Surpluses double Further, even with the volume of UPI transactions growing 425% over the last five years, the quantum of surpluses transferred by the RBI to the Union government has grown at more than double that rate. "The costs have to be



The costs have to be paid by someone... we all want that this public infra should continue to strengthen. Let's wait and watch

SANJAY MALHOTRA, RBI Governor

paid by someone," Mr. Malhotra said. "We all want that this public infrastructure should continue to strengthen. Let's wait and watch for further developments on this." "The cost is already getting passed on," he added. "It may not be directly on to the very user, but someone is paying the cost. This is what I meant when I said someone will have to pay the cost. What is important is that we continue

kinds of transactions that can attract such a charge. Cost of running UPI According to sources in the government, the proposal to allow banks to levy an MDR is currently limited to a small sub-set of merchants – those with an annual turnover of ₹1-1.5 crore – and to transactions above ₹2,000 in value. However, the wording of the Bill provides an avenue for this charge to be levied on a wider set of transactions in the future. According to banking industry officials, the UPI platform currently costs about ₹0.4-1 per transaction to operate and maintain. Official data shows that 24,161.69 crore UPI transactions were conducted in 2025-26. This would

peg the cost of running the platform at ₹9,664-24,161 crore per year. The RBI earned approximately ₹4.3 lakh crore in 2025-26. Out of this, it transferred about ₹2.9 lakh crore to the Union government as surplus for 2025-26. The cost of running the UPI platform that year would have worked out to 3-8.5% of this amount. RBI surplus transfers have grown from ₹30,307.45 crore in 2021-22 to about ₹2.9 lakh crore in 2025-26, a growth of 857%. Over this period, the volume of UPI transactions grew 425%. This shows that, even with this rapid growth in UPI adoption, the RBI surpluses have grown more than enough to cover the cost of all UPI transactions.

India emerges strong from each disruption, says Malhotra

Lalendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Asserting that India's macroeconomic fundamentals are "very strong", RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said the country had emerged strong with each disruption. "Even this particular episode [West Asia conflict] of shock is being treated as an opportunity for us to further enhance our re-

silience," he said. "Our macroeconomic fundamental is very strong, growth is resilient, inflation, although headline is going up, the underlying inflation pressures are muted while we are aligning with core inflation," Mr. Malhotra said. Answering a question from The Hindu during his post Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting press conference in Mum-

bai on Wednesday, he said, "We have not only faced these challenges [COVID, Russia-Ukraine war, Israel-West Bank conflict, U.S. tariffs and the ongoing West Asia conflict] but have come out stronger." Asked how confident he was, Mr. Malhotra said, "confidence comes from the way the Indian economy, including us [RBI] and other institutions have faced these challenges."

Lalendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Currency notes made out of polymers (plastic) will be in circulation in the country from next financial year, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said on Wednesday. "We are still at a pilot [stage]. We will test, check as to how they [the polymer currency notes] perform in the Indian condi-

There will be several security features in the new notes, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said

tion, climate and other infrastructure we have put in place. And thereafter we will see if we need to further scale it up as it is or with changes," Mr. Malhotra said while answering a

question at the post Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) press conference. "We are targeting that they [the polymer notes] are in circulation, if everything goes as planned, in the beginning of next financial year," he said. "Testing will be done, security clearance is required and there will be several security features in the new notes," the Governor added.



Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited
(A Govt. of India Enterprise & Group Company of IndianOil)
[CIN-L40101TN1965GOI005389]
Regd. Office: No.536, Anna Salai, Teynampet, Chennai-600 018. Tel: 044-24346807/24349959
Email Id: lalitkumar.mohanty@cpcl.co.in Website: www.cpcl.co.in

Further to our Newspaper Publication regarding subject "Notice of the 60th Annual General Meeting" vide two newspapers "The Hindu" and "Makkal Kurral" dated. 02.08.2026, this is to inform that due to unavoidable obligatory development and administrative commitments, the 60th AGM of the Members of the Company has been rescheduled from **Monday, August 24th 2026 at 11:00 AM to Wednesday, August 26th, 2026 at 12:00 Noon (IST)** through Video Conference ("VC") / Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM"). Accordingly, the revised notice of 60th AGM which is already sent to the shareholders through their registered email id on 04.08.2026 is issued herewith for information.

REVISED NOTICE OF 60th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

NOTICE is hereby given that the **60th Annual General Meeting ("AGM")** of the members of Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited ("Company") is re-scheduled to be held on **Wednesday, the 26th August 2026 at 12:00 Noon (IST)** through Video Conference / Other Audio Visual Means ("VC/OAVM") to transact the businesses as set out in the notice of the AGM.

Notice of AGM and Annual Report:

In compliance with the MCA & SEBI Circular(s), the revised Notice setting out the businesses to be transacted at the 60th AGM together with the Integrated Annual Report of the Company for the year 2025-26 **has been sent on Tuesday, the 04th August 2026** through electronic mode to the members whose email address is registered with the Company / Depository Participant(s). The Revised Notice is also available on the Company's website <https://www.cpcl.co.in/investors/financials/exchange-intimations/> and on the website of the Stock Exchanges, i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com respectively, and on the website of KFin Technologies Ltd. at www.kfintech.com.

Accordingly, following amendments to Notice of 60th AGM is hereby submitted for information and dissemination.

Sl.No.	Events	Original Dates	Revised Dates
1	Date of the AGM	24.08.2026 at 11.00 AM	26.08.2026 at 12.00 Noon
2	Record Date	07.08.2026	07.08.2026
3	Cut-off Date	17.08.2026	19.08.2026
4	Speaker Registration Date	20.08.2026 to 22.08.2026	22.08.2026 to 24.08.2026
5	Question Registration Date	20.08.2026 to 22.08.2026	22.08.2026 to 24.08.2026
6	E-Voting Date	20.08.2026 (9.00AM) to 23.08.2026 (5.00 PM)	22.08.2026 (9.00AM) to 25.08.2026 (5.00 PM)

It is hereby confirmed that except above dates, there is no other changes in the notice of the 60th AGM.

Remote e-voting and e-voting during AGM:

The Company provides to the members through KFin Technologies Ltd., the facility to cast their vote(s) on the business as set out in the Notice of the 60th AGM through remote e-voting facility ("remote e-voting") as well as during the AGM to those members who could not cast their vote(s) through remote e-voting. Members are requested to note the following:

- any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a member of the Company after dispatch of the Notice and holds shares as on the cut-off date, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at evoting.cpcl@kfintech.com. However, if the member is already registered with KFin Technologies Ltd. for remote e-voting then he/she can use their existing User ID and password for casting the vote.
- the members who have cast their vote through remote e-voting prior to the AGM can also attend / participate in the AGM through VC / OAVM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again at the AGM. the Revised remote e-voting module shall be disabled by KFin Technologies Ltd. after **5.00 PM (IST) on Tuesday, August 25th, 2026**. The votes once cast by the member, cannot be changed subsequently.
- those members, who intend to participate in the AGM through VC / OAVM facility and could not cast their vote on the resolutions through remote e-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting during the AGM.
- the manner of voting for members holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for members who have not registered their email address has been provided in the Notice of the AGM.

Members are requested to carefully read all the Notes set out in the Notice of the AGM with respect to instructions for joining the AGM, manner of casting vote etc.

Contact Details:

In case of any queries related to e-voting, the members may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for members and e-voting user manual for members available at the download section of <https://evoting.kfintech.com> or call on toll free no.: 1800-309-4001 or contact Mr.Mohd. Mohsin, Asst. Vice President, KFin Technologies Ltd., at the designated email ID: evoting.cpcl@kfintech.com or Phone No.: +91 40 6716 1700 / 09177401094 to get their grievances on e-voting addressed.

For Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited
Sd/-
(LALIT KUMAR MOHANTY)
Company Secretary
M.No. F6655

Place : Chennai
Dated : August 4th, 2026



A ND-NDE

DUBAI

Yemen's Houthis say they attacked Saudi tanker off Yanbu in Red Sea



Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis said on Wednesday they had launched a missile attack on a Saudi oil tanker off the coast of the kingdom's Red Sea port city of Yanbu. The Houthis' military spokesperson, Yahya Saree, did not say when the attack took place. Saudi officials did not respond to a request for comment. REUTERS

ANKARA

Turkish MPs back conditional amnesty for Kurdish militants



A majority of Turkish MPs on Wednesday backed limited and conditional amnesty for PKK Kurdish militants, a first legislative step to end decades of deadly fighting. Entitled "Strengthening National Solidarity and Social Integration," the Bill, which will be put to a vote soon, was signed by 360 of 592 MPs. AFP

CEUTA

Ceuta warns of 'unsustainable' plight for child migrants, seeks aid



The leader of Spain's north African territory of Ceuta on Wednesday said the number of children left there after last week's rush of migrants was "unsustainable", pleading for government aid. Juan Jesus Vivas said that authorities were taking care of 1,100 youngsters against a theoretical capacity of 90. AFP

WASHINGTON

Trump administration revokes visa of Brazil's Ambassador to the U.S.



The United States has revoked the visa of Brazil's Ambassador to the U.S., Maria Luiza Ribeiro Viotti, in retaliation for Brazil's denial of visas for two American diplomats who sought to visit ahead of elections as well as what it said was Brazil's stalling on approving President Donald Trump's nominee to be Ambassador in Brasilia. AP

New Hormuz route agreed, to be managed jointly with Oman: Iran

The geographical coordinates of the route envisaged by the two countries have been agreed upon, and a joint statement, containing the main considerations and points of agreement, is in the final drafting stage, says Tehran's Foreign Ministry

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran and Oman have agreed to a route for ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz and are putting the final touches on arrangements for jointly managing the passage, Tehran's Foreign Ministry said on Wednesday.

Iran has seized *de facto* control of the strait, a strategic waterway for the global energy trade, since the U.S. and Israel launched their war against the country on February 28.

U.S. President Donald Trump has repeatedly insisted Tehran is keen to do a deal to reopen the route



Motorists drive past a large billboard pledging revenge against Donald Trump along Jomhouri Street in central Tehran. AFP

to shipping, but Iran denies this and says it will instead make arrangements with its neighbour across the strait, Oman.

"The geographical coor-

dinates of the route envisaged by the two sides have been agreed upon and, if certain third parties do not obstruct the process, the joint statement of the two

countries, containing the main considerations and points of agreement, is also in the final review and drafting stage," spokesperson Esmail Baqaei said, according to state news agency IRNA.

According to the report, Mr. Baqaei told presspersons that talks with Oman were moving forward, but that even if an understanding was reached, it would not mean that the strait had become safe for all passing vessels.

"The factors making the Strait of Hormuz insecure still exist on the part of the United States, particularly the naval blockade and other aggressive and threa-

tening actions against Iran and its interests," he said.

Mr. Trump had said Tuesday a deal with Iran to reopen Hormuz could happen "tomorrow or the next day," telling reporters in California that negotiators "had a very good day".

"The strait is going to be open very soon, or they're going to get hit very hard – and then the strait's going to be open," Mr. Trump said in an interview with Fox News.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Tuesday that the United States was involved in negotiations between Oman and Iran on increasing traffic through the Strait of Hormuz.

Russian barrage on Kyiv kills 17; defences fall short

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian attacks on Kyiv and its surrounding region killed 17 people and wounded dozens, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Wednesday, as Ukraine's depleted air defences failed to stop any of Moscow's incoming missiles overnight.

The barrage, which lasted about two hours, was the latest in a series of large-scale Russian missile strikes that have become almost routine this summer. Moscow is exploiting Ukraine's critical shortage of interceptors for the U.S.-made Patriot systems, the sole air defence weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles.

Mr. Zelenskyy has pleaded with other coun-



Railway workers gather on railway tracks next to bodies in plastic bags of people killed during Russian strikes on Wednesday. AFP

tries, especially the United States, to send more of the ammunition made scarcer by the Iran war. Failing that, he wants to make Patriot ammunition in Ukraine.

Mr. Zelenskyy said after a Russian aerial attack on Friday night that air defences shot down only one ballistic missile "solely be-

cause there are no missiles for the Patriots".

The targets hit in the barrage included a brewery, a warehouse for construction material, and a mail sorting office that had nothing to do with the war, Mr. Zelenskyy said. But Russia's Defence Ministry said the businesses had military ties.

Dhaka turns Hasina's official residence into memorial museum

Press Trust of India
DHAKA

Amid tightened nationwide security, Bangladesh on Wednesday inaugurated a memorial museum at the official residence of ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina to commemorate the victims of violence during the anti-government protests in 2024 that toppled her government.

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman inaugurated the 'July Mass Uprising Memorial Museum' at Ganabhaban, Prime Minister's official residence during Ms. Hasina's regime, coinciding with the day she left to India on August 5, 2024.



Mr. Rahman announced that government institutions would be named after slain activists of the uprising and those who were killed during the rule of Ms. Hasina's Awami League since 2009.

According to a UN report, up to 1,400 people were killed between July 15 and August 15 last year.

China announces countermeasures against Washington

Associated Press
BANGKOK

China announced a series of economic measures on Wednesday against the United States, including controls on exports of drones to the U.S. and a ban on dealings with six American entities, in response to recent restrictions imposed by Washington.

Tensions are simmering between the world's two biggest economies ahead of an expected visit by Chinese President Xi Jinping to the U.S. in September, despite signs of warming ties during his meetings with U.S. President Donald Trump in Beijing in May.

The Commerce Ministry

said the sanctions are in response to recent moves from the U.S., including a ban by the U.S. Federal Communications Commission on imports of Chinese drones, and the Department of Homeland Security's decision to add 43 Chinese companies to the Uyghur Forced Labour Prevention Act entity list to prevent imports of goods made with forced labour.

The "measures seriously violate the important consensus reached by the two heads of state and severely damage China's legitimate rights and interests. China has no choice but to take necessary countermeasures in response," the Ministry said.

Abdul El-Sayed wins Michigan Senate primary in major win for progressives

Associated Press
DETROIT

Abdul El-Sayed has won Michigan's Democratic nomination for U.S. Senate, defeating U.S. Representative Haley Stevens in a massive victory for the party's progressive wing in a battleground state.

The real test of Mr. El-Sayed's and progressives' strength will now come in a November match-up against Republican Mike Rogers, a former congressman who ran unopposed for the GOP nomination. The seat is pivotal to Democrats' chances of flipping the Senate and Mr. El-Sayed will face the challenge of uniting a divided Democratic base after a



Massive support: Abdul El-Sayed speaks during a news conference at the Spirit of Detroit, in Michigan, on Wednesday. AP

bruising primary.

The race remained tight throughout Tuesday night, with a winner not declared until early Wednesday. In his final remarks at a primary night party before the race was called, Mr. El-Sayed said, "tomorrow we begin to mend fences".

Mr. El-Sayed's win represents a significant shift for the Democratic Party; in 2018, he lost the gubernatorial primary to now-Governor Gretchen Whitmer by 21 percentage points.

Mr. El-Sayed, a former health official, campaigned

on "Medicare for All," halting military aid to Israel and campaign finance reform. He had support from progressive leaders including Senator Bernie Sanders and U.S. Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, who framed the race as a grassroots-focused movement and a broader fight against the establishment and big-money spending.

Now comes the more difficult challenge for Democrats: uniting the party to defeat Mr. Rogers, for whom Republicans have already reserved large sums of money ahead of the general election. Democrats consider the seat a must-win if they are to flip control of the Senate this year.

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE
No. SRDEE-TRD-BSB-2026-27-T14
Date: 04.08.2026
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/ TRD, North Eastern Railway, Varanasi for and on behalf of President of India, invites sealed "OPEN" E-Tender for the following work: **Tender Reference No.:** SRDEE-TRD-BSB-2026-27-T14; **Name of Work:** 25 KV Electrification work in connection with Modification of Chhapra Kacheheri Yard of N.E. Railway, Varanasi Division.; **Approx. Cost (in ₹):** ₹2,57,30,492.36; **Earnest Money (in ₹):** ₹5,14,600/-; **Cost of Tender documents (in ₹):** Nil; **E-Tender closing date and time:** 26.08.2026 upto 14:45 hrs.; **Completion Period:** 9 Months; • Open E-Tender Online will be submitted upto 14:45 Hrs. on 26.08.2026. For Full details and submission of bid kindly visit the official website of Indian Railway i.e. www.irops.gov.in.
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/ CPRO/EL-v26
DO NOT SMOKE BIDI/CIGARETTE IN TRAINS

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE
No.: NER-BSB0SnT-OT-42-2026
"Open Tenders" through Online (E-Tendering) are invited by Divisional Railway Manager (Signal & Telecom)/Varanasi/N.E. Railway for and on behalf of the President of India for the following works. **SN :** 1. **Tender Notice No. and Description of Work:** NER-BSB0SnT-OT-42-2026. **Name of work :** Provision of 6 Quad cable for axal counter in IBH section as media redundancy. (Total 4 IBH). **Details :** **Approx. Value :** ₹14469448.77; **Earnest Money :** ₹289400.00; **Cost of Tender Form :** ₹00.00; **Completion period :** 180 DAYS; **Tender Closing date & Time :** 28/08/2026 UPTO 15:00 बजे. 1. Tender Online will be submitted upto 15 Hrs. on date 28/08/2026. 2. For full details and submission of bid kindly visit the Official website of Indian railways i.e. www.irops.gov.in
Divl. Rly. Manager (S&T) CPRO/Signal-90 Varanasi
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THE HINDU
India's National Newspaper

NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF URBAN MANAGEMENT (NIUM), HYDERABAD

CORRIGENDUM - EXTENSION OF EOI SUBMISSION DATE
With reference to EOI No. NIUM-UP/5/1/2026-PH-NIUM dated **18.07.2026** for Empanelment of Consulting Firms/ Agencies the last date for submission of applications has been **extended from 05.08.2026 (5:00 PM) to 12.08.2026 (5:00 PM)**. All other terms and conditions of the EOI remain unchanged. For details, visit www.nium.org.in.
Sd/- Director General NIUM
DIPR R.O. No. : 393-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:05-08-2026

अखिल भारतीय आयुर्विज्ञान संस्थान (अ.भा.आ.सं.), भुवनेश्वर
ALL INDIA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES (AIIMS), BHUBANESWAR
(A Statutory body under aegis of Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Govt. of India)
Sijua, Post-Dumduma, Bhubaneswar (Odisha) -751019
File No. RECT-11014/3/2026-RECU SEC Dated: 05-08-2026

NOTIFICATION
ADVT. NO. - DEPUTATION/02/2026
Sub- Recruitment of various Group 'A', 'B' and 'C' posts on Deputation Basis at AIIMS Bhubaneswar.
All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Bhubaneswar, an Autonomous Institute of National Importance, is one of the newer AIIMS and an apex healthcare Institute established by the **Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India**, under the **Pradhan Mantri Swasthya Suraksha Yojana (PMSSY)** with the aim of correcting regional imbalances in quality tertiary level healthcare in the country and attaining self-sufficiency in undergraduate, postgraduate & higher medical education, research and training.
Applications are being invited in prescribed pro-forma (Hard Copy Only) from eligible officials of Central / State / U.T. Governments / Statutory / Autonomous Bodies / Government Universities / Government Research and Development Organizations etc. as applicable to fill the below mentioned various Group 'A', 'B' and 'C' posts on **Deputation Basis** at **All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Bhubaneswar**.

Sl.	Name Of the Post	Group	Pay Scale as per 7th	Vacancy
1.	Medical Superintendent	A	Level 14 + NPA	1
2.	Chief Librarian	A	Level 13	1
3.	Registrar	A	Level 12	1
4.	Senior Analyst (System Analyst)	A	Level 12	1
5.	Chief Nursing Officer	A	Level 12	1
6.	Senior Administrative Officer	A	Level 11	1
7.	Senior Procurement Cum Store Officer	A	Level 11	1
8.	Nursing Superintendent	A	Level 11	3
9.	Chief Dietician	A	Level 11	1
10.	Chief Medical Social Service Officer	A	Level 11	1
11.	CSSD Officer	A	Level 11	1
12.	Principle Private Secretary	A	Level 11	1
13.	Librarian Selection Grade (Senior Librarian)	A	Level 11	1
14.	Chief Medical Record Officer	A	Level 10	1
15.	Private Secretary	B	Level 7	3
16.	Chief Pharmacist	B	Level 7	1
17.	Senior Sanitation Officer	B	Level 7	1
18.	Manager/ Supervisor/ Gas Officer	B	Level 7	1
19.	Junior Administrative Officer	B	Level 6	9
20.	Sr. Pharmacist	B	Level 6	3
21.	Pharmacist Grade I	B	Level 6	11
22.	Medical Record Officer	B	Level 6	4
23.	Sanitation Officer	B	Level 6	3
24.	Personal Assistant	B	Level 6	6
25.	Senior Administrative Assistant (UDC)	C	Level 4	3
Total				61

For comprehensive details regarding the eligibility criteria, essential educational qualification, age and other terms & conditions, please refer to **Advt No. DEPUTATION/2/2026 Dated 04.08.2026**, available on the Institute's official website <https://aiimsbhubaneswar.nic.in>
Sd/-
(Md. Salim Golder)
Administrative Officer
AIIMS, Bhubaneswar

कार्यालय नगर निगम जयपुर

पण्डित दीनदयाल उपाध्याय भवन, लालकोठी, जयपुर
क्रमांक :- जसस / 2026 / 199 दिनांक :- 03.08.2026
अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना क्रमांक :- 13-14 / 2026-27
नगर निगम जयपुर हेतु सीवर जेटिंग मशीन तथा सुपर सकार मशीन क्रय किये जाने हेतु पंजीकृत फर्स से ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र, विस्तृत सूचना एवं शर्तें आदि सम्पूर्ण विवरण वेबसाइट www.jaipurmc.org, www.spppraj.nic.in and www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in पर स्टेट पब्लिक प्रोक्यूरमेन्ट के UBN No. JMC2627GLOB00309 to JMC2627GLOB00310 पर देखी जा सकती है।
राज.संवाद / सी / 26 / 8758 असीक्षण अभियन्ता (गैरराज)

CHALLENGING TIMES

Last 10 months tested me in ways I never expected: Neeraj



There are throws that travel far, and then there are moments that carry the weight of an entire journey. The past 10 months tested me in ways I never expected. To be back competing at this level feels good. None of this would have been possible on my own — Neeraj Chopra in an Instagram post.

SELF APPRAISAL

Deep down, I always told myself I was a ‘big club’ player: Vozinha



The decision was very clear. Despite playing in smaller leagues for clubs that weren't exactly giants, deep down I always told myself I was a 'big club' player. So when Colo-Colo came calling, there was no doubt. From day one, I knew where I wanted to play. I received many offers, but Colo-Colo was always the priority — Vozinha.

STRONG STANCE

‘Deceitful’ Infantino has debased the office of FIFA president: Figo



I could write 10,000 words on the problems at FIFA. But the solution needs only three: Infantino must go. Infantino has debased the office of FIFA president that he promised to elevate. He has lied, deceived and tried to feather his own nest. It is too late to save his dignity, but it is not too late to save football — Luis Figo.

INJURY WOES

Carlos Alcaraz withdraws from the Cincinnati Masters



Carlos Alcaraz has withdrawn from the ATP Cincinnati Masters as he recovers from a wrist injury that has sidelined him since April. The 23-year-old had been slated to make his return in the tune-up for the US Open, where he is the defending champion. The seven-time Slam champ had also pulled out of French Open and Wimbledon.

Sindhu and Lakshya handed easy openers in the Worlds

Ayush draws top-ranked Shi Yu Qi first up; the fifth-seeded pair of Satwiksairaj and Chirag receives a bye into the second round; chief National coach Gopichand optimistic of India's chances in the championship

BADMINTON

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

P.V. Sindhu will kick-start her pursuit of a sixth World Championship medal against Sophia Noble of Ireland but the road to the top will be anything but easy for most Indians after a mixed bag in the draw here on Wednesday. With a 64-player draw for men's and women's singles, there are no byes for seeded players, unlike the doubles which is a 48-pair event allowing the 16 seeded pairs, including fifth seeds Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty to advance to round two. Placed in the top half of the draw, Sindhu is likely to run into China's Wang Zhi Yi in the pre-quarters, followed by Putri Kusuma Wardani of Indonesia and then a possible semifinal against top-ranked An Se Young.

Lakshya Sen, meanwhile, will begin against Collins Valentine Filimon of Austria but the road to the final is peppered with possible tough outings against World No. 2 Kunlavut Vitidsarn, Christo Popov or Alex Lanier and then Loh Kean Yew or Victor Lai starting from pre-quarterfinals onwards. Ayush Shetty drew the short end of the stick, being handed an opening-round clash against defending champion and World No. 1



Ready for the battle: Lakshya opens against Filimon while Ayush faces a huge challenge against World No.1 Shi. GETTY IMAGES



Shi Yu Qi in a repeat of their Asian Championships final. Chief National coach Pullela Gopichand was cautiously optimistic of India's chances. "I think it's great to see the World Championships come back to India after 17 years. And the difference now is that India as a nation, sporting-wise and badminton-wise has grown. We're looking at many stars who could end up on the podium. "Having said that, it's a

Last year, they (Sat-Chi) had eight semifinals and two finals so the results were quite consistent. Game-wise, they are getting better now

KIM TAN HER
Doubles coach

tough event. We have a couple of tough initial rounds, especially Ayush against Shi Yu Qi. Sindhu

has done well in Japan, Unnati has a favourable draw. Overall, happy with the way the draw has come out," Gopichand said on the sidelines of the draw.

Injury worries
Doubles coach Kim Tan Her, meanwhile, insisted that the players were all fit but admitted that recurring injuries have been a hurdle to sustained success. "Last year, they (Sat-Chi) had eight semifinals

and two finals so the results were quite consistent. Game-wise, they are getting better now. Confidence, okay. But what's bothering them is the injury. That's bothering me and bothering them also. Especially for Satwik, his shoulder, it's on and off. Hopefully this time, he can overcome," Kim hoped. The World Championships are scheduled at the revamped Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium here from August 17-23.

Sindhu's ambitious plan to groom future champions

Anirudh Velamuri
VISAKHAPATNAM

P.V. Sindhu and Andhra Pradesh IT & HRD Minister Nara Lokesh laid the foundation stone for the P.V. Sindhu Centre for Sports Excellence here on Wednesday, marking the beginning of an ambitious project aimed at nurturing the next generation of India's Olympic athletes.

Spread across nearly two lakh square feet, the campus has been envisioned as an integrated sports and education ecosystem.

What began as an initiative focused solely on badminton expanded into a multi-sport project following discussions with AP Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu and will now cater to seven disciplines – badminton, table tennis, swimming, shooting, football, basketball and chess. The vision, Sindhu said, was to create a place where every discipline would receive equal importance from the outset.

To prepare for the project, Sindhu and her husband, Venkata Datta Sai, spent their vacations studying some of the world's leading sports facilities, visiting centres in Doha, Milan and Australia, among others. The trips, she said, became learning opportunities as they sought to understand global best practices in sports infrastructure and athlete development, joking that she now needed a "holiday from all her holidays."

"We put our sweat and blood into it. I can confidently tell you that it will be a world-class centre



Great expectations: Sindhu, seen with Andhra Pradesh Minister Nara Lokesh, hopes the Centre for Sports Excellence will help nurture the next generation of India's Olympic athletes. K.R. DEEPAK

and, at the same time, it will be an institute where people will actually be like, 'Wow, this is what we need in our state and in the country,'" Sindhu told *The Hindu*.

Scheduled for completion by May 2028, the facility will allow children to experience multiple sports before choosing a discipline to specialise in, with the broader aim of creating a pathway to build elite athletes.

Reflecting on the significance of the project, Sindhu said it represented a legacy beyond her achievements on the court.

"Sport has given me and taught me so much. It is a big project and is not easy, but at the same time I wanted something on this scale. I want to show people that we have a lot of talent and if we give them the world-class facilities, I'm sure you will see a lot of kids go on to bag medals for the state and the nation," she remarked.

"India gave me the opportunity to win two Olympic medals, which changed

my life. And this institution is how I carry that opportunity forward. My medals will always be my greatest honour and I hope this centre becomes my greatest contribution. Olympic medals inspire a generation, but institutions build generations."

The facilities: Badminton: Nine international-standard courts, capable of hosting BWF International Challenge level tournaments.
Table Tennis: Nine professional grade tables with a dedicated performance training hall.
Swimming: 25-metre performance pool designed for elite training and conditioning.
Shooting: Indoor ranges at 10m and 25m, built for national and international level competition preparation.
Chess: Dedicated high-performance training space for advanced coaching and competition readiness.
High-Performance Engine Room: An 8,000 sq. ft. Strength and Conditioning Arena, one of the largest in India and benchmarked against global centres including Aspetar in Doha, houses sports science, performance tracking, load monitoring, physiotherapy, recovery systems and yoga and wellness facilities.

Tanvi leads a strong women's show, men disappoint

Press Trust of India
ASAN (SOUTH KOREA)

Taipei Open champion Tanvi Sharma led a strong Indian showing in women's singles, but K. Srikanth suffered an opening-round exit in men's singles at the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament here on Wednesday. Third seed Tanvi eased past China's Yuan An Qi 21-16, 21-15 to progress to the second round. Srikanth, also seeded third, lost to Israel's Daniil Dubovenko. Kiran George, Mithun Manjunath, Tharun Mannepilli, Rounak Chouhan and Saneeth Dayanand made first-round exits.

The results (first round): Women: Tanvi Sharma bt Yuan An Qi (Chn) 21-16, 21-15; Rakshitha Ramraj bt Yoo A. Yeon (Kor) 22-24, 21-12, 21-13; Mansi Singh bt Kim Joo Eun (Kor) 14-21, 21-19, 21-9; Isharani Baruah bt Lee So Yul (Kor) 21-18, 15-21,



Smooth start: Tanvi had it easy in the first round. FILE PHOTO

21-7; Anmol Kharb bt Lo Sin Yan Happy (HK) 16-21, 21-17, 21-12; Ashmita Chaliha bt Riko Hiramoto (Jpn) 22-20, 21-18; Shriyanshi Valishetty bt Pai Yu Po (Tpe) 21-15, 21-14; Hina Akechi (Jpn) bt Tanya Hemant 21-16, 22-20; Kim Min Ji (Kor) bt Aakarshi Kashyap 20-22, 23-21, 21-3.
Doubles: Sonali Singh & Ritika Thaker bt Bang Ji Sun & Hyun Ji Jang (Kor) 13-21, 21-15, 21-12.
Men: Daniil Dubovenko (Isr) bt K. Srikanth lost 22-20, 14-21, 21-12; Park Sang Yong (Kor) bt Kiran George 21-15, 21-9; Zhu Xuan Chen (Chn) bt Mithun Manjunath

21-11, 21-9; Yoo Tae Bin (Kor) bt Tharun Mannepilli 21-13, 12-21, 21-19; Jeon Hyeok Jin (Kor) bt Chouhan 23-21, 21-19; Yudai Okimoto (Jpn) bt Saneeth Dayanand 21-11, 13-4, ret'd.
Doubles: Aaron Chia & Aaron Tai (Mas) bt Bhargav Ram Arigela & Viswa Tej Gobburu 21-17, 21-15.
Mixed doubles: Ishaan Bhatnagar & Shruti Mishra bt K. Sathwik Reddy & Radhika Sharma 20-22, 21-10, 21-15; Loo Bing Kun & Nurul Maisarah Mohamad Zamani (Mas) bt Dhruv Rawat & K. Maneesha 18-21, 21-14, 21-17.

Asunta denies charges, questions Ethics Committee jurisdiction

HOCKEY

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

Former Indian women's hockey team captain and selector Asunta Lakra has not only denied all allegations made against her by another player but also questioned the jurisdiction of the Ethics Committee itself and the maintainability of the proceedings against her. "I deny each and every allegation, insinuation and imputation levelled against me in the said complaints, whether express or implied... The allegations are false, baseless, malicious, motivated, defamatory and are a complete distortion of facts," Asunta wrote in a detailed preliminary reply to the chairman of Hockey India's Ethics Committee Justice (Retd) Raghvendra Kumar on Wednesday. Asunta, who has levelled serious allegations of sexual

misconduct against coach Sudhir Golla and criminal intimidation against Hockey India Secretary-General Bholanath Singh, had complaints filed against her by Albela Rani Toppo and had been asked to reply by August 5. "Both the complaints in question are, on their own face, addressed to the Secretary-General, Hockey India, and not to the President, Hockey India... Under the scheme of the bylaws of Hockey India adopted on 20th June, 2026 and the Code of Ethics framed thereunder, the Ethics Committee is not a body of original or suo-motu jurisdiction... A complaint referable to the Ethics Committee must first be placed before, examined by and referred in writing by the President, Hockey India, who alone performs the gatekeeping function. "Until such a written reference is made by the President, the Ethics Commit-

tee is not, and cannot be, seized of the complaint, and no inquiry – fact-finding or otherwise – can be commenced against any person," she stated. She also questioned the veracity of the notice issued to her "at the instance of the secretary-general" given that he is a person of interest in the matter. Asunta also questioned the constitution of the Ethics Committee and the authority of the chairman to hold an enquiry, issue notice or record findings singly. "The Ethics Committee is a collegiate body which must act as a body and through a validly constituted quorum," she wrote. Seeking complete documents including a copy of the president's referral, HI bylaws and all communication on the matter, she sought four weeks' time from receiving the requested documents while reserving the right to file civil and criminal proceedings in a court of law.

Pakistan secures series-levelling win

CRICKET

Associated Press
PORT OF SPAIN

Pakistan ended its eight-match losing streak away from home in Test matches with a resounding eight-wicket victory over West Indies in the second match on Wednesday. First-innings century-maker Abdullah Shafique and Babar Azam led Pakistan to 77 for two with unbeaten knocks of 24 each as the visitor achieved victory shortly after lunch on day four, drawing the series 1-1. Earlier, the host had set up a modest target of 75 after it got bowled out for 117 inside half an hour, with off-break bowler Sajid Khan (four for 32) and left-arm spinner Ali Usman (four for 39) sharing eight wickets between them. Brandon King couldn't bat in West Indies' second



Sajid Khan. AFP

innings due to a back injury sustained on day three.

The scores: West Indies 344 & 117 in 46.1 overs (Ali Usman 4/39, Sajid Khan 4/32) lost to Pakistan 387 in 115 overs (Azan Awais 55, Abdullah Shafique 160 n.o., Babar Azam 88, Jomel Warrican 6/112) & 77/2 in 23.3 overs. **PoM:** Shafique; **PoS:** Greaves & Babar.

INBRIEF



Arsenal agrees to £75 million Guimaraes deal: reports

Arsenal has reportedly agreed a £75 million fee with Newcastle to sign captain Bruno Guimaraes. The Brazil midfielder's future has been the subject of fevered speculation for weeks since it emerged he wanted to leave Tyneside for the Emirates Stadium.



Salah arrives in Istanbul ahead of Trabzonspor move

Mohamed Salah was greeted by cheering Trabzonspor fans in Istanbul on Wednesday as he closed in on a move to the Turkish club. The Liverpool icon wore the team's blue and burgundy striped shirt after flying in on a private jet to complete the deal. "Trabzon are you ready? I can hear you. See you very soon," Salah said in a video message posted on the club's X profile.

National junior u-18 clay court tennis from August 8

The 33rd edition of the MCC-N. Sankar Memorial National junior u-18 clay court tennis championship will be held from August 8 to 15 at the Madras Cricket Club (MCC) courts in Chennai. The tournament is organised by MCC in association with the Tamil Nadu Tennis Association under the aegis of the All India Tennis Association. The qualifying rounds will begin on August 8, while the main draw starts on August 10. The doubles finals are scheduled for August 14, followed by the singles finals on August 15. The top 120 boys and 104 girls from across the country will feature in the singles and doubles events.

LIVE TELECAST

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 4 & 7 p.m.

TNPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official Youtube channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague), 7.30 p.m.

Dhull powers Kings to fourth straight win

DPL

Sports Bureau

NEW DELHI

Yash Dhull's unbeaten 100 (47b, 6x4, 9x6) powered Central Delhi Kings to a nine-wicket rout of Purani Dilli 6 in the Delhi Premier League at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Wednesday.

With rain affecting proceedings once again, the contest was confined to 15 overs per team.

The win was set up by the Kings bowlers, who restricted Purani Dilli to 140 for seven in 15 overs. Opting to bowl given the inclement weather in the national capital, Kings seized the initiative through Money Grewal.

The 25-year-old pacer claimed three scalps in his opening burst. With Lalit Yadav and Samarth Seth dismissed soon after, Anuj Rawat & Co. were reeling at 55 for five in the ninth over.

It was courtesy a rear-guard stand of 85 runs between Ashwini Chillar and Rohan Rathi that Purani Dilli recovered to get to a competitive score.

However, it wasn't enough to prevent Kings from registering a fourth straight win in the competition.



Blistering knock: Yash Dhull, left, scored an quickfire century to guide Central Delhi Kings home. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Dhull, who has been named in the North Zone squad for the Duleep Trophy starting on August 23, was in total control in the middle, stitching together a 60-run opening stand with Siddharth Joon and an unbroken alliance of 81 with Yugal Saini.

Fittingly, Dhull's single to reach the target of 141 in 13.2 overs also saw him accomplish the three-figure mark. For Purani Dilli, Gaurav Saroha was the lone wicket-taker.

Sarthak excels
In the second match,

A calculated risk which paid off handsomely for Sakshi at the CWG

The boxer's coach Chhote Lal Yadav says she has a good chance to win a medal at the Asian Games too; praises her skills and endurance

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

A calculated risk to drop from 54kg to 51kg paid off for newly-crowned Commonwealth Games champion Sakshi Chaudhary, as she finally made an impact at a multi-sport event.

A former World junior champion, two-time World youth champion, Asian championships bronze medallist and World Boxing Cup gold medallist, Sakshi secured most of her international medals in 54kg.

Hunger for success
Hungry for success at a multi-sport event, the gutsy Sakshi sought the advice of her coach Chhote Lal Yadav at the Army Sports In-



The big punch: Sakshi's coach says she made good use of her superb left jab during the gold medal-winning run in Glasgow. ANI

stitute (ASI) in Pune, and decided to switch to 51kg after the National championships in January, when

boxers were allowed to change weight categories.

For Sakshi, it was a risky decision as the lower

weight class had several accomplished boxers, including double World champion Nikhat Zareen and

reigning World champion Meenakshi Hooda.

"Since (another Army boxer) Preeti (Pawar) was doing well in the 54kg, it made sense for Sakshi to come down to 51kg. She was capable of beating everyone. Once we made the make-or-break decision, I asked her to keep quiet as it could have backfired," Chhote Lal told *The Hindu*, as his ward stayed busy attending felicitation functions.

Key qualities
"Only a few boxers have qualities like Sakshi. She is aggressive, has good endurance and has a superb left jab, which she used effectively in Glasgow. Even during her training at the ASI, she used to beat male boxers because of the jab. I

am sure she will medal at the Asian Games as well."

Former Indian women's team head coach Bhaskar Bhatt, under whom Sakshi claimed her maiden World youth gold in Guwahati in 2017, appreciated her performance.

"Sakshi didn't stop for a moment during her bouts at the Commonwealth Games and didn't give her opponents any chance. It shows how much work she has put in to increase her endurance and strengthen her legs.

"She should work on two areas to become even more effective. She needs to connect her punches with the full knuckle to unleash maximum power and stop using her elbow to stay away from trouble," said Bhatt.

Pragg leads after rapid phase



Anish and Praggnanandhaa face off. FLICKR/GRANDCHESTOUR

CHESS

Press Trust of India

ST. LOUIS

Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa topped the rapid section of the St. Louis Rapid and Blitz, scoring 12 points out of a possible 18 to keep his hopes alive for a place in the Grand Chess Tour (GCT) finals.

Praggnanandhaa lost the ninth and final round in the rapid section to GM Jorden van Foreest but still

managed to retain a one-point lead, finishing ahead of Javokhir Sindarov.

There are 18 more blitz games to be played before the winner is determined for the \$200,000 prize pool out of which \$50,000 goes to the champion.

Standings after rapid: 1. R. Praggnanandhaa (12); 2. Javokhir Sindarov (11); 3. Wesley So (11); 4-7: Levon Aronian, Leinier Dominguez Perez, Anish Giri, Vincent Keymer 9 each; 8-9: Fabiano Caruana, Jorden Van Foreest 8 each; 10. Awonder Leong (5).

Indian Army eases past Baghpat, on top of Group B; Indian Navy blanks NEROCA

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau

KOLKATA

Indian Army stormed to the top of Group B with a dominant 4-0 victory over Baghpat FC in a group league match of the 135th Durand Cup tournament here on Wednesday.

The Army side produced a fine first-half performance, with Samir Mur-

mu, Saikhom Borish Singh, Shubham Rana, and Christopher Kamei finding the net in succession to seal their team's second successive win.

The win also took Indian Army to six points from two matches and moved it ahead of Samaleswari FC – also on six points – on the basis of a superior goal difference. Baghpat, which suffered its third consecutive defeat, exited

the tournament without a point.

In the other match of the day, Indian Navy FT beat NEROCA FC 2-0 in a Group D encounter in Imphal. Roshan Panna opened the scoring in the first half before E. Muhammed Inayath doubled the lead after the break to seal the Sailors' first win. Indian Navy had lost its opening fixture 0-1 to local side FC Raengdai.

The win lifted Indian Navy to three points from two matches, leaving it second in the group behind FC Raengdai (six points).

The results: Group B: (Kolkata): Indian Army FT 4 (Samir Murmu 11, Saikhom Borish Singh 22, Shubham Rana 35, Christopher Kamei 45+3) bt Baghpat FC 0.

Group D (Imphal): Indian Navy FT 2 (Roshan Panna 23, Muhammed Inayath 65) bt NEROCA FC 0.

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Tale of the tape – a study in extremes and an unsettled championship

Five different winners in five races, a title fight that keeps rewriting itself every fortnight. It hasn't all been smooth sailing under the new rules. If this is what growing pains look like, Formula 1's new era is at least proving it can keep everyone guessing



All to drive for: Antonelli, Russell and Hamilton are in a battle for the top prize. AP, REUTERS

R.K. Arjun

Halfway through 2026, Formula 1 has delivered everything except a settled championship. A rookie in a Mercedes built a 66-point lead, then watched it evaporate to 25 in less than a month. A four-time champion resurrected the Red Bull while many were questioning whether he would continue in Formula one. A team that hadn't won all season suddenly looked unbeatable in Budapest. Five different winners in five races and a title fight that keeps rewriting itself every fortnight. It hasn't all been smooth sailing under the new rules. Moments like Silverstone's software blunder and driver complaints about battery-dependent racing are hard to romanticise. However, if this is what growing pains look like, Formula 1's new era is at least proving it can keep everyone guessing.

George Russell converted pole into victory in the season opener at Albert Park, fending off an early Charles Leclerc charge before a Virtual Safety Car handed Mercedes the decisive strategic edge. Kimi Antonelli recovered from a poor start to complete a Mercedes 1-2, with Leclerc salvaging third after Ferrari's one-stop gamble backfired late on. Lewis Hamilton finished fourth, just six-tenths behind his teammate. While Max Verstappen produced the drive of the day, recovering from 20th on the grid to 6th.

Shanghai belonged to F1's newest wonderkid. After Russell claimed Saturday's Sprint, his Mercedes teammate stole the spotlight in the Grand Prix, converting pole into a maiden F1 win at just 19 years old – becoming the youngest polesitter in the sport's history in the process. Hamilton surged into an early race lead but couldn't hold off Antonelli's recovery, eventually settling for a maiden Ferrari podium in third as Russell completed a second consecutive Mercedes 1-2. It was a weekend to forget for reigning title holders, with both McLaren cars failing to make the start after electrical issues on the grid.

History was made once again at Suzuka. Antonelli claimed his second consecutive win, recovering from a wheelspin-hit start that dropped him to sixth before an Ollie Bearman crash triggered a mid-race Safety Car which swung the race back in his favour. The result meant that he became the first teenager to win back-to-back races. Oscar Piastri secured McLaren's first podium of

the season in second, with Leclerc completing the podium after edging out his teammate in a tense intra-Ferrari fight. Russell, starting from second, could only manage fourth. Antonelli carried a nine-point lead over Russell into F1's first month-long break, the youngest championship leader in the sport's history after consecutive wins in China and Japan.

As the season resumed in Miami, the Italian made it three wins in a row, holding off a race-long challenge from Lando Norris. Pole-sitter Antonelli locked up alongside Verstappen and Leclerc into Turn 1, with the Red Bull spinning out shortly after and triggering an early Safety Car following separate crashes for Isack Hadjar and Pierre Gasly. The lead changed hands repeatedly through the race, with Norris and Piastri both enjoying spells at the front before Antonelli reasserted control. Piastri completed the podium in third, while Leclerc's afternoon ended in the wall, completing the story of a disappointing return for Ferrari after the break.

Canada brought heartbreak for one Mercedes driver and history for the other. Russell led from pole and looked set for victory in Montreal, only for a late power unit failure to hand Antonelli his fourth win in a row. Hamilton profited from the chaos to claim his best Ferrari finish yet in second, while Verstappen finally found his first podium of the season in third. This result stretched Antonelli's lead at the top to 43 points. Monaco descended into chaos, and the Mercedes wonderkid simply drove away from it with a dominant lights-to-flag victory after Verstappen's front-row start ended in a stall and immediate retirement. Leclerc's podium bid crashed out late on a crumbling track surface, while his Ferrari teammate secured back-to-back second-place finishes. Once again, the day's biggest fallout fell to Russell, who was hit with a pit-lane speeding penalty en route to a forgettable finish outside the points. Antonelli's championship lead stood at a staggering 66 points as he secured his fifth win in six rounds.

Hamilton finally ended his Ferrari drought in style at the newly-hosted Barcelona-Catalunya Grand Prix, converting an aggressive undercut strategy and a well-timed Virtual Safety Car stop into his first win for the Scuderia, 686 days after his last victory. Russell and Norris completed a historic all-British podium. Championship leader Antonelli's

dominant start finally hit a snag, retiring just four laps from the finish after briefly passing his teammate. The result cut Antonelli's lead to 50 points, ending Mercedes' perfect run to open the season.

Mercedes reclaimed track dominance, as Russell secured his second win of the season at the Red Bull Ring. Antonelli endured a rough afternoon, running wide twice in the opening laps and admitting he'd gotten "too excited," while Max Verstappen produced a strong recovery from fifth to finish second after his own qualifying crash. Russell's win cut Antonelli's championship lead to 40 points, though the Mercedes rookie's third place was enough to protect his advantage. Ferrari, meanwhile, endured a quiet weekend, with both cars finishing outside the top four.

Leclerc ended a winless run stretching back to Austin 2024 in the most chaotic way imaginable, crossing the line first at Silverstone after Antonelli's late mechanical failure handed him control of the race. But the headlines belonged just as much to the finish itself: a "Safety Car In This Lap" message was shown in error before being withdrawn, and the race ended fully behind the safety car for the first time since Monza 2022. Russell claimed second after a bold tyre gamble paid off, Hamilton completed the podium, and the championship leader was classified a distant 16th after a penalty compounded his misfortune.

The Italian driver bounced back from a difficult month with a commanding win at Spa, losing the lead twice. First to Verstappen off the line through Eau Rouge, then to a Ferrari strategy masterstroke during a Virtual Safety Car sequence. The Italian teenager reclaimed the lead on the Kemmel Straight with six laps to go. Leclerc held on for second despite never getting back into range, with Verstappen completing the podium. The result was overshadowed early on by Russell's opening-lap retirement, colliding with Hamilton at Turn 6 as his race ended in the gravel, while Hamilton was handed a five-second penalty for his part in the incident. Norris salvaged some points, finishing seventh from 13th on the grid after a gamble on Safety Car timing didn't pay off, though he did set the race's fastest lap on the final tour. The win stretched Antonelli's championship lead to 45 points. McLaren finally had their day, but it came with a side of internal drama. Oscar Piastri seized the lead from teammate Lando Norris at Turn 1 and

controlled the race for its first half, until he was hit by a lapped Carlos Sainz. The delay in getting past the Williams was enough for Norris to overcut his teammate at the second stop. The Australian's afternoon went from bad to worse as he not only lost time in traffic but a late gearbox on Lap 56 forced a retirement. The resulting Virtual Safety Car proved a lifeline for Antonelli, who used it to recover from a seventh-place grid slot to a damage-limiting third. Verstappen secured second through an extended tyre strategy. Hamilton crossed the line fourth only to be demoted to fifth by a late pit-lane speeding penalty, his fourth infraction in three race weekends/

Formula 1's 2026 season has been a study in extremes. It began with a bang in Melbourne under a radically overhauled rulebook: no DRS, new power units, a fresh chassis philosophy, and quickly found its star: Kimi Antonelli. The 19-year-old won five of the first six races of the season, becoming the youngest points leader in the sport's history and building a 66-point championship lead by Monaco. Then the season turned. A retirement in Barcelona let Hamilton end a 686-day victory drought in stunning fashion for his first win in red. A mistake-strewn Austria let Russell back into the fight. Silverstone's chaotic, software-error-marred finish handed Leclerc his first win in nearly two years while gutting Antonelli's result entirely. By the time the sport reached Spa, Antonelli's once-commanding lead had been cut to just 25 points.

Spa and Hungary, though, showed exactly why he still leads. A composed recovery drive in Belgium and a damage-limiting third place in Budapest, despite starting from a penalised seventh, which stretched his advantage back out to 50 points heading into the summer break, even as Norris finally delivered McLaren's first win of the season.

Now, after a month-long break, the sport will resume at Zandvoort for the final Dutch Grand Prix under the current promoter agreement.

Verstappen's home race arrives at a pivotal moment for Red Bull, who are still searching for their first win of the season. Beyond that, Monza, a maiden Madrid GP, and Singapore's Sprint finale await before the season turns toward its final leg. With Antonelli's lead sizeable but not unassailable, and Ferrari and McLaren both building momentum, the second half promises to be as exciting as the first.

THE GIST

The 2026 season began with a bang in Melbourne under a radically overhauled rulebook: no DRS, new power units, a fresh chassis philosophy

Antonelli won five of the first six races of the season, becoming the youngest points leader in the sport's history and building a 66-point championship lead by Monaco

With Antonelli's lead sizeable but not unassailable, and Ferrari and McLaren both building momentum, the second half promises to be just as combustible as the first



